



PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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Correction of errors of substance may be made only on the floor of the House with the permission of the Speaker. However, correction of typographical or grammatical errors which Members suggest for the Bound Volumes which will be compiled at the end of the Meeting may be clearly marked in the Daily Report, and the copy containing the corrections submitted at the Editor's Office, Parliament House, not later than four clear days after the publication of the Daily Report.

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

FIRST MEETING, 2026

Friday, 13th February, 2026

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 2:56 p.m.*

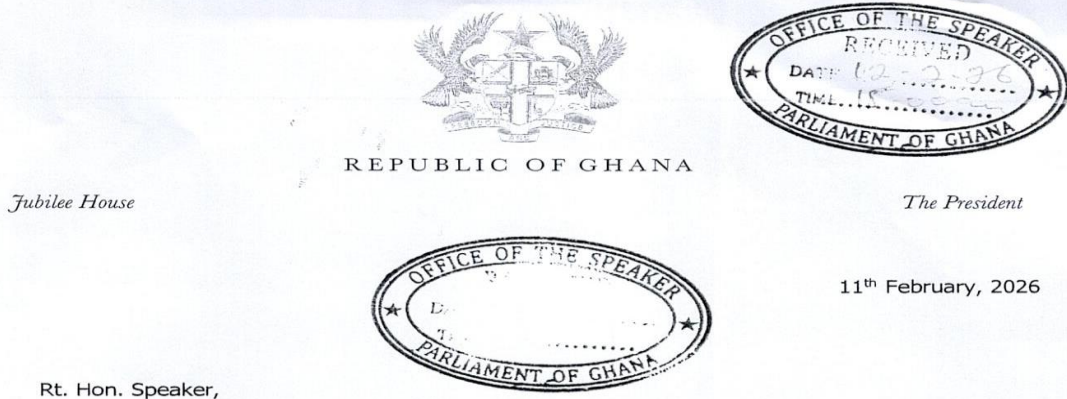
[HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER, MR
BERNARD AHIAFOR, IN THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

COMMUNICATION FROM THE
PRESIDENT

Absence from Ghana

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon
Members, there is a Message from His
Excellency the President.



ABSENCE FROM GHANA

In accordance with Article 59 of the 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana, I write to formally notify you of my intention to travel outside the country on 12th February, 2026 to Addis Ababa, Ethiopia, to participate in the 39th Ordinary Session of Assembly of Heads of State and Government of the African Union, scheduled to take place from 13th to 17th February, 2026.

I am expected to return to Ghana on Monday, 16th February, 2026.

In my absence, the Vice President, Professor Naana Jane Opoku-Agyemang, shall perform my functions in accordance with Article 60 (8) of the Constitution.


JOHN DRAMANI MAHAMA

**THE RT. HON. SPEAKER
OFFICE OF PARLIAMENT
PARLIAMENT HOUSE
ACCRA**

*(2) Clerk/Usheon
B.U. to be read to
the House on 12/2/26*

cc: The Vice President
Jubilee House
Accra

The Chief of Staff
Jubilee House
Accra

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, kindly take note, and let the records show. There is no Formal Communication by the Speaker. We will then move to take the item numbered 5, Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I hold in my hand the *Votes and Proceedings* of Thursday, 12th February, 2026, for correction.

Hon Members, Page 1...20.

[No correction was made to the Votes and Proceedings of Thursday, 12th February, 2026]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have two *Official Reports*. The *Official Report* of 5th February, 2026 and 6th February, 2026.

Let us start with the *Official Report* of 5th February, 2026; Hon Members, it is before you for correction. Any corrections?

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, thank you.

Column 92, paragraph 3, on the second line, the phrase should be, “we introduced”, but it was captured as “we introduce”. They can take note of that. Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Table, take note.

Any further corrections?

Hon Members, the *Official Report* of Thursday, 5th February, 2026, as corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Hon Members, let us turn to the *Official Report* of 6th February, 2026 and make corrections on same. Any corrections?

[No correction was made to the Official Report of Friday, 6th February, 2026]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, having dealt with the item numbered 5, permit me to acknowledge the presence of our revered students in our midst.

First on the list is Great Stars Academy. They are led by Donyo Elias, who is the headmaster. They are from Anyaa, Sowutuom, and are 72 in number.

We also have Ayawaso Central Social Studies Teachers, led by Esther Addo, a teacher. They are from Ayawaso Central and are 8 in number.

Again, we have Redeemed King of Glory International School, led by Aryeh David, the headmaster. They are from

the Ablekuma South Constituency and are 36 in number.

Also, we have Oblogo MA Basic 1 School, led by Mary Ansah, the headmaster. They are 64 in number.

We have Golden Royal International School, led by Joseph Quansah, the headteacher. They are from the Efutu Constituency and are 56 in number.

We have Awutu True Light International School, led by Gabriel Agyeman and Michael Dufe Annan, headteacher and supervisor, respectively.

[Pupils of Great Stars Academy were acknowledged.]

[Members of the Ayawaso Central Social Studies Teachers were acknowledged.]

[Pupils of Redeemed King of Glory International School were acknowledged.]

[Pupils of Oblogo MA Basic 1 School were acknowledged.]

[Pupils of Golden Royal International School were acknowledged.]

[Pupils of Awutu True Light International School were acknowledged.]

3:06 p.m.

Hon Members, on your behalf, I welcome them to Parliament of Ghana and urge them to have a fruitful visit to Parliament.

Hon Members, let us take the item numbered 6—Presentation of the Business Statement for the third week by the Chairman of the Committee.

Chairman of the Committee, will you please present the Business Statement?

BUSINESS OF THE HOUSE

Chairperson of the Committee/Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, the Committee met yesterday, Thursday, 12th February, 2026 and arranged Business of the House for the Third Week ending Friday, 20th February, 2026.

Mr Speaker, the Committee accordingly submits its Report as follows:

Arrangement of Business

Formal Communications by the Speaker

Mr Speaker, you may read any available communication to the House.

Question(s)

Mr Speaker, the Business Committee has scheduled the following ministers to respond to Questions asked of them during the Week

No. of Question(s)

i. Minister for Education	11
ii. Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry	4
iii. Minister for Roads and Highways	11
iv. Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy, and Religious Affairs	9
v. Minister for the Interior	9
vi. Minister for Energy and Green Transition	15

Total Number of Questions**59**

Mr Speaker, in all, six (6) ministers are expected to attend upon the House to respond to Fifty-Nine (59) Questions during the Week. The Questions are of the following types:

- i. Urgent – 1; ii. Oral – 58

Statements

Mr Speaker, pursuant to Order 91(2), Ministers of State may be permitted to make Statements on Government policy. You may also admit Statements by Hon Members in accordance with Order 93.

Bills, Papers and Reports

Mr Speaker, in accordance with Order 159, Bills may be presented to the House for First Reading. However, those of urgent nature may be taken through

the various stages in a day in accordance with Order 160.

Pursuant to Order 97, Papers may be laid during the week and reports from Committees may also be presented to the House for consideration.

Motions and Resolutions

Mr Speaker, Motions may be debated and their consequential Resolutions, if any, taken during the week.

Referrals at Committee

Mr Speaker, the Business Committee, once again reminds the House of the backlog of referrals before Committees, and urge Leadership of Committees to prioritise and expedite consideration of the referrals and promptly report to the House in accordance with Order 267 (4).

Mr Speaker, once again, we urge the leadership of committees to pay attention to our call to bring their various referrals for us to take those referrals. We indicated that starting from next week, we will do mandatory taking of reports. We would schedule you, and then you must mandatorily bring your report so that we take it.

Conclusion

Mr Speaker, in accordance with Order 216 (2) and subject to Order 67, the Committee submits to the House the order in which the Business of the House shall be taken during the week.

Tuesday, 17th February, 2026

Roll Call

National Pledge

Statements

(a) **Ms Dorcas Afo Toffey (Jomoro):** To make a Statement on addressing Violence against Women and Girls.

(b) **Ms Zuwera Mohammed Ibrahimah (Salaga South):** To make a Statement in memory of Honourable Hajia Mary Salifu Boforo – former Member of Parliament for Savelugu Constituency.

(c) **Dr Mahama Tiah Abdul-Kabiru (Walewale):** To make a Statement on the decline of youth financing from the

District Assembly Common Fund (DACF) to the National Youth Authority (NYA) and the Youth Employment Agency (YEA).

(d) **Mr Joseph Kwame Kumah (Kintampo North):** To make a Statement on the urgent call to establish a Health Security Fund for Ghana.

Questions

Q.180. Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie (Odododiodioo): To ask the Minister for Education for an update on the Millennium Schools Project initiated in 2011 and whether the government remains committed to its objective of eliminating the shift system in public basic schools.

Q. 221. Mr Peter Lanchene Toobu (Wa West): To ask the Minister for Education what plans the Government has regarding the insufficient furniture situation in numerous schools across the country as it hinders teaching and learning.

Q. 224. Mr Robert Wisdom Cudjoe (Prestea Huni-Valley): To ask the Minister for Education the urgent steps the Ministry is taking to address the situation in the Prestea Huni-Valley constituency, where a significant number of classrooms are being managed by community teachers who are paid by parents.

Q. 252. Ms Mavis Kuukua Bissie (Ahanta West): To ask the Minister for

Education when the government will complete and operationalise the Takoradi Technical University campus at Aketekyi in the Ahanta West Constituency which has remained abandoned for the past eight years.

Q.267. Mr Emmanuel Tobbin (Anyaa Sowutuom): To ask the Minister for Education what the plans of the Ministry on the abandoned 3-storey building and 18-unit classroom block situated at Israel Park in the Ga Central Municipality.

Q.285. Mr Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo (Manso Nkwanta): To ask the Minister for Education when the Pakyi Applied Technology Institute (Ghana TVET Service) be furnished with needed logistics such as: classroom furniture, dormitory beds, transport facility, and furnishing of the dining hall.

Q.324. Mr Samuel Awuku (Akuapem North): To ask the Minister for Education the steps the Ministry is implementing to address the infrastructural deficit inherent in special need schools in Akuapem North Constituency (School for the Blind and School for the Deaf).

Q.397. Mr Daniel Dung Mahama (Talensi): To ask the Minister for Education when the Bolgatanga Senior High School located at Winkogo in the Talensi district will be fenced.

Q.420. Mr Ralph Poku-Adusei (Bekwai): To ask the Minister for Education what interventions are in place to expand digital learning tools and

reliable internet access to public schools in rural and peri-urban areas.

Q.421. Ms Damata Ama Appianimaa Salam (Afigya Kwabre South): To ask the Minister for Education what steps the Ministry is taking to address TEWU-Ghana's exclusion from university governing councils per the "GTEC's TEWU-TUC-ONLY" directive and how the Ministry intends to ensure fair dialogue and industrial harmony.

Q.483. Mr Charles Asiedu (Tano South): To ask the Minister for Education the current status and the plan of the Ministry for the completion of the following GETFund financed infrastructure projects at St. Joseph's College of Education in Bechem; (i) a two-storey dormitory block (ii) a two-storey administration block (iii) a three-storey students' hostel.

Q.286. Dr Isaac Yaw Opoku (Offinso South): To ask the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry the status of the Komenda Sugar Factory.

Q.315. Mr Michael Okyere Baafi (New Juaben South): To ask the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry the status of the vehicle component manufacturing policy.

Q.316. Prof Kingsley Nyarko (Kwadaso): To ask the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry the specific interventions the Ministry has

taken to stimulate domestic production, increase export volumes and add value to our products to boost trade earnings.

Q.401. Mr Lawrence Agyinsam (Hemang – Lower Denkyira): To ask the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry the plans of the Ministry to increase exports to take advantage of the current cedi performance as well as increase the share of the trade sector to Ghana's GDP.

Presentation of Papers

i. Presentation and First Reading of Bills

- (a) Human Sexual Rights and Family Values Bill, 2025.
- (b) Constitution of the Republic of Ghana (Amendment) Bill, 2025.

ii. Motions

iii. Consideration Stage

- Intestate Succession Bill, 2025.

iv. Committee Sitings

Wednesday, 18th February, 2026

Roll Call

Statements

(a) **Mr Davis Ansah Opoku (Mpreaso) and Mr Abed-Nego Bandim (Bunkprugu):** To make a joint Statement on strengthening key institutions to drive Ghana's Digital Transformation and Inclusion: Lessons from participating in the GIZ-Supported Tech Policy Fellowship.

(b) **Mr Issah Atta (Sagnarigu):** To make a Statement on opportunities for trade facilitation within and among African countries: challenges, weaknesses, and the way forward.

(c) **Mrs Joycelyn Quashie (North Dayi):** To make a Statement on the 2025 International Day for the Elimination of Violence Against Women.

Urgent Question

(#) **Mr Frank Afriyie (Afadjato South):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways what is the outcome of Government's value-for-money audit ordered in 2017 and the current status of cocoa road projects in the country.

Questions

Q.617. Mr Mohammed Adamu Ramadan (Adentan): To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the following roads will be completed in view of the fact that the contractors have

left the site: (i) Lotto Kiosk to Hotel Junction (ii) Roman Junction to New Legon.

Q.550. Dr Grace Ayensu-Danquah (Essikado Ketan): To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the immediate and long-term interventions being taken to rehabilitate the Kojokrom to Nkroful Junction stretch of the Accra – Elubo road.

Q.614. Mr Alhassan Umar (Zabzugu): To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the abandoned bridge between Kuntumbiyili and Ogbunja will be re-awarded to a new contractor.

Q.634. Mr Kofi Arko Nokoe (Evalua Ajomoro Gwira): To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the Gwira Wiaso – Gwira Maham bridge over the River Ankobra linking the Evalua and Nzema areas in the South to the Gwira and Wassa North will be constructed.

Q.565. Mr Akwasi Konadu (Manhyia North): To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when construction will resume on the (i) Buokrom junction – Abease road (ii) Dote Inner Town Road (iii) Duase New Site Road.

Q.566. Mr Ohene Kwame Frimpong (Asante Akyem North): To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the immediate plans to construct the following roads, which connects most farming communities within the Municipality: (i) Abrewapong Road (ii)

Hwidiem to Yeyi – Asenkyem (iii) Anenekrom to Nyiayeso (iv) Aninsua to Domeabra.

Q.579. Mr Bright Asamoah Brefo (Bibiani / Anhwiaso/ Bekwai): To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the plans the Ministry has for the construction of the 3.5KM Bibiani bypass which starts from Mess Junction and ends at Mortar Junction.

Q.661. Ms Ida Adjoa Asiedu (Ayensuano): To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the urgent steps the Ministry is undertaking to construct the broken bridge in the Amanase township.

Q.581. Mr Francis Asenso Boakye (Bantama): To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways whether the Ministry is aware of the newly announced proposal by H.E. President John Dramani Mahama to construct a new six-lane Accra -Kumasi expressway and provide details including its scope, feasibility studies, estimated cost, funding and implementation timelines.

Q.582. Mr Kwame Anyimadu-Antwi (Asante Akim Central): To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the trenches beside the main road at Konongo – Kumasi Road will be covered to guarantee the safety of passengers.

Q.199. Dr Albert Tetteh Nyakotey (Yilo Krobo): To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy, and Religious Affairs the plans of the Ministry for the rebuilding of the Klo-Agogo and the Nkrakan markets in Yilo Krobo Constituency.

Q.313. Prof Kingsley Nyarko (Kwadaso): To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy, and Religious Affairs the total number of churches in the country and the number of them that are registered.

Q.675. Dr Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlins (Klottey-Korle): To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs when the Novotel Market will be rebuilt.

Q.364. Mr Kwame Appiah Kodua (Fanteakwa North): To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs the measures implemented for the final completion of the Begoro Central Market.

Q.365. Mr Maxwell Kwame Lukutor (South Tongu): To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs the plans of the Ministry to upgrade the Assemblies which were conferred with Municipal/Metropolitan status last year and when the Legislative Instrument will be passed for the Assemblies to be inaugurated.

Q.395. Mr Daniel Dung Mahama (Talensi): To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Regional Affairs when the Upper East Region will receive the Toyota Hilux that were distributed to the other regions in 2024.

Q.526. Mr Martin Adjei-Mensah Korsah (Techiman South): To ask the Minister for Local Government,

Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs whether the reports of DRIP machines being used at Galamsey Sites have come to his attention, and what the Ministry is doing to ensure accountability in the use of the said machines.

Q.436. Mr Duke William Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta (Fanteakwa South): To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious affairs what steps are being implemented to ensure the timely completion of 618 infrastructure projects and 60 markets under the Gulf of Guinea Social Cohesion (SOCO) Project.

Q.438. Mr Charles Owiredi (Abirem): To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs to provide an update on the elevation of the Birim North District Assembly to a municipal status by President Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo Addo on 7th November, 2024.

Motions

(a) That this Honourable House adopts the Report of the Finance Committee on the Annual Public Debt Management Report for the 2024 Financial Year.

(b) That this Honourable House adopts the Report of the Finance Committee on the Annual Report on the Management of the Energy Sector Levies and Accounts for the year 2024

(c) Second Reading of Bills

- Ghana Deposit Protection (Amendment) Bill, 2025.

(d) Third Reading of Bills

- Legal Education Reform Bill, 2025.

Consideration Stage

- Governance Advisory Council Bill, 2025.

Committee Sittings

Thursday, 19th February, 2026

Roll Call

Statements

(a) **Dr Thomas Winsum Anabah (Garu):** To make a Statement on closing the Physician Gap in Ghana—Global Perspectives and Strategic Options.

(b) **Mr Charles Asiedu (Tano South):** To make a Statement on the Urgent need to revitalise the Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company Limited.

(c) **Mr Richmond Edem Kofi Kpotosu (Ho Central):** To make a Statement on the UHAS Leads Ghana in Global Impact Rankings- A Beacon of Health, Innovation and Development.

Questions

Q.635. Mr John Ntim Fordjour (Assin South): To ask the Minister for the Interior the total number of Ghanaians who became refugees in Ivory Coast and Burkina Faso during the Gbenyiri conflict and the plans of the Ministry to relocate them back to Ghana.

Q.636. Mr John Ntim Fordjour (Assin South): To ask the Minister for the Interior the total number of victims displaced during the Gbenyiri Conflict and what steps the Ministry is taking to restore the displaced victims to their homes.

Q.471. Mr Alexander Akwasi Acquah (Akim Oda): To ask the Minister for the Interior whether the Ministry recently presented some pick up vehicles for the 24Hour Economy Secretariat, and the source of those vehicles.

Q.569. Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong (Kwabre East): To ask the Minister for the Interior how the Ministry intends to monitor and evaluate the effectiveness of the new Independent Police Complaints Commission in rebuilding public trust and enhancing police professionalism.

Q.570. Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong (Kwabre East): To ask the Minister for the Interior what specific actions have been implemented so far by the Ghana Police Service in investigating the violence that occurred during the rerun of the parliamentary elections in Ablekuma North Constituency.

Q.571. Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong (Kwabre East):

To ask the Minister for the Interior what institutional or operational lapses were identified by the Ghana Police Service and other security agencies in their post-incident review of the Ablekuma North violence and how these will be addressed ahead of future elections.

Q.588. Mr Anthony Mmieh (Odotobri):

To ask the Minister for the Interior the immediate and medium-term interventions the Ministry is undertaking to enhance police infrastructure and strengthen security service delivery within the Amansie Central District.

Q.596. Mr Felix Akwetey Okle (Bortianor Ngleshie Amanfro):

To ask the Minister for the Interior what plans the Ministry has to curb the increasing crime rate, especially land guard-related crimes within the Ga South Municipality.

Q.650. Mr Richard Kuuire (Nandom):

To ask the Minister for the Interior when the proposed police station at Ko in the Nandom Constituency will be constructed and operationalised to combat escalating crime and enhance community security.

Presentation of Papers

Motions

- (a) That this Honourable House constitutes an Ad-Hoc Committee made up of the following Members to

recommend for appointment by Parliament an Auditor to audit and report on the Financial Statements of the Office of the Auditor-General for the Year ended 31st December, 2024:

1. Hon Kofi Benteh Afful
Chairman

2. Hon Matthew Nyindam
Member

3. Hon Atta Issa Member

(b) Third Reading of Bills

- Governance Advisory Council Bill, 2025.

Committee Sittings

Friday, 20th February, 2026

Roll Call

Statements

(a) Mr Lawrence Agyinsam (Hemang Lower Denkyira):

To make a Statement on the importance of connecting entrepreneurs in Micro, Small and Medium-Sized Enterprises landscape in Ghana.

(b) Mr Kweku Asante-Boateng (Asante Akim South):

To make a Statement on tragic road accident around Juaso on the Accra-Kumasi Highway.

(c) **Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong (Kwabre East):** To make a Statement on the Challenges of the Cashew Industry in Ghana.

Questions

Q.307. Mr William Ntebe (Tatale-Sanguli): To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition to provide an update on the cost-sharing electrification projects in the following communities: (i) Unibado (ii) Nachambu (iii) Naloo (iv) Sabonjida (v) Tikassarini.

Q.308. Prof Titus Kofi Beyuo (Lambussie): To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition when the abandoned electrification projects in the following communities will be completed: (i) Kuntawii (ii) Suke number one (1) (iii) Nicheli (iv) Karni Karesele (v) Kelegan

Q.366. Mr Nelson Kofi Djabab (Krachi East): To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition the plans of the Ministry to connect the following island communities to the national grid of electricity: (i) Beposu (ii) Nyarkornakpoe (iii) Atsivikope (iv) Tumikope (v) Sikape (vi) Jerusalem.

Q.652. Mr Ebenezer Alumire Ndebilla (Zebilla): To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition when stalled rural electrification projects in the Zebilla Constituency will be completed.

Q.390. Mr Michael Kwasi Aidoo (Oforikrom): To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition how the attempted berthing of MT Marlin Ametrine outside the revised laycan

schedule occurred and what measures are being taken to prevent such regulatory lapses and future disruptions.

Q.671. Mr Stanley Yaw Nandaya (Wulensi): To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition the plans of the Ministry to extend electricity to the remaining sixty-two communities in the Wulensi Constituency and the plans the Ministry has to connect the following communities, which have been wired since 2017, to the national grid: (i) Sakpe (ii) Gonguni (iii) Bangniyili.

Q.391. Mr Mumuni Muhammed Nurideen (Nalerigu/Gambaga): To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition the specific measures the Ministry is taking to solve the persistent power outage in the Nalerigu/Gambaga constituency.

Q.540. Mr Issah Salifu Taylor (Tarkwa/Nsuaem): To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition when the following communities in the Tarkwa Nsuaem Constituencies will be connected to the national grid: (i) Ebussem (ii) Esuoso (iii) Nyamease (iv) Aklika (v) Krobofo (vi) Ekurase (vii) Kwesikrom (viii) Pataho Brenya (ix) Bepoekyir.

Q.670. Mr Elvis Osei Mensah Dapaah (Ahafo Ano South West): To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition the plans of the Ministry to expand electricity connection in the following communities: (i) Prang (ii) Abua (iii) Adjaraja – Beposo (iv) Fawoman (v) Dama-Nkwanta (vi) Abeasi (vii) Komfuorkrom (viii)

Zabrama (ix) Yawpare (x) Benim (xi) Cherambo and Kamanpa.

Q.576. Mr Ohene Kwame Frimpong (Asante Akyem North): To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition what plans are being implemented to extend the rural electrification project to the following communities in the Asante Akyem North municipality: (i) Oforikrobon (ii) Scorpion (iii) Niena (iv) Baamaa (v) Aworoso (vi) Abrekyiekrom (vii) Jabal.

Q.591. Mr Mohammed Issah Bataglia (Sissala East): To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition the plans of the Government to expand electricity to the following communities in the Sissala East Constituency: (i) Santijan, (ii) Gbenabisi (iii) Kalaxy, (iv) Nahadakui (v) Kapunjan (vi) Tanla (vii) Nitalu (viii) Kwapung (ix) Wuru (x) Dinduarijan Katinia and seven other communities to the national grid.

Q.593. Mr Mohammed Issah Bataglia (Sissala East): To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition the status of work on the Baweisiboi and Kormor Rural Electrification project.

Q.592. Mr Kwame Appiah Kodua (Fanteakwa North): To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition the plans the Ministry has to support developmental projects, which are in dire need of VRA Resettlement in the following communities in the Fanteakwa North District: (i) Dede –

Sewirako, (ii) Onuku (iii) Dominase Quarters.

Q.605. Alhaji Alhassan Mumuni (Salaga North): To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition the effort the Ministry is making to connect the following communities in the Salaga North Constituency to the national grid: (i) Zankum (ii) Nom-nayili (iii) Chandayili (iv) Nyeshila (v) Nyeshila – Kpalguni (vi) Chihigu (vii) Chani (viii) Chihigu Fulani Settlement (ix) Kpashegu – Kpalguni (x) Sungshe Fulani.

Q.606. Alhaji Alhassan Mumuni (Salaga North): To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition the plans the Ministry has to connect the following communities to the national grid: (i) Bavim (ii) Komlanyili (iii) Kaa (iv) Changbuni (v) Diffisa (vi) Kejipulari (vii) Dingoni (viii) Gbeteni (ix) Chanayili (x) Epuneyirema (xi) Kpalan (xii) Ruwandogo Bator.

Presentation of Papers

Motions

(a) Third Reading of Bills

- Intestate Succession Bill, 2025.

Committee Sitings

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Business Statement has been presented by the Chairman of the Business Committee, in the person of the Majority Leader and Leader of

Government Business. It is now time for your comments.

Yes, I recognise the First Deputy Minority Chief Whip.

First Deputy Minority Whip (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, I would like to draw the Majority Leader's attention to the fact that if next week he could programme the Minister for Food and Agriculture, Minister for Finance and the Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of COCOBOD, because yesterday the Minister for Finance had announced—about policy. Being the people's representative, we should be briefed on the haircut that has been given to cocoa farmers. We should also be briefed on the price reduction from GH¢3,625.00 to some GH¢2,800.00 with about GH¢1,000.00 cut off.

So, during the Committee of the Whole, we would have these three key people, the Minister for Food and Agriculture, Minister for Finance and the CEO of the COCOBOD, so that we would be properly briefed on this. We are hearing of upcoming demonstrations from the cocoa farmers because they are unhappy. The representatives of the people have not been briefed and we do not know what is going on. So if the Hon Minister could be summoned to brief us in a Committee on the Whole. Majority Leader, the situation is very bad.

Yesterday, a lot of people were going to lose their life as a result of what the Government did. People have lost confidence in farming cocoa, and people are very sick about this whole issue. It is

very sad and as somebody who cares, we should be able to do something with regards to this.

Mr Speaker, it is very important because yesterday, the reactions we heard after the Minister's announcement were very bad and as we representatives of over 30 million Ghanaians need to be briefed properly. Yesterday, we heard that some people lost their lives as a result of what this Government did [**Some Hon Members: Eiiii!!!**—So, there must be a deliberate thing to be able to deliver.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, with all due respect, our Standing Orders are very clear. At the time allotted for Statements, you can get up to raise an issue of urgent public importance. But when you are called upon to comment on the Business Statement, your comment should be on the Business Statement. It will therefore amount to an abuse of the Standing Orders when the time is not ripe for you to seek leave of the Speaker, to bring the attention of the House to a matter of urgent public importance, instead of commenting on the Statement, then you are doing that. When it comes to the time allotted for Statement, where the law allows you so to do, what then are you going to do?

Yes, let me hear from Hon Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah?

Mr Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah: Mr Speaker, I want to commend the Majority Leader and the team, the Business Committee, for putting on this

Business Statement Report that there will be a first presentation of Human Sexual Rights and Family Value Bill, 2025, which was presented as a Private Member's Bill.

Mr Speaker, Hon Colleagues from the other Side thought that this Side of the House would not present this Bill, and therefore I want to commend him highly for adding it to our Business and prioritising it. I just want to plead with the Business Committee that even though this Bill should not go through a Certificate of Urgency, we will take it through all the stages and make sure that it is passed in this House.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Patrick Yaw Boamah?

Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah: Mr Speaker, the presentation of the Business Statement for next week, under Paragraph 2(c), is a captioned "Statements" that; "pursuant to Order 91(2), Ministers of State may be permitted to make Statements of government policy. You may also admit statements by Hon Members in accordance with Standing Order 93."

Mr Speaker, with your kind permission, Standing Order 91(2) states;

"A Minister of State may make a statement of government policy and the statement shall

(a) be limited to facts which are necessary to be made known to the House."

Mr Speaker, it is on this premise that I support the call by the First Deputy Minority Whip that the Hon Minister for Finance, who has overview of the cocoa sector, and also the Minister for Food and Agriculture and the Chief Executive of the Ghana Cocoa Board, must appear.

Mr Speaker, it is very important that the Minister for Finance, who has sectorial overview of the cocoa sector, be made to come to present a Statement which will require of you, respectfully, to even call for a Committee of the Whole on this very important matter. Mr Speaker, the people of Ashanti Region, Volta Region, Western Region, Central Region, Eastern Region, Bono, Ahafo, Bono East, are the dominant cocoa producing regions.

3:16 p.m.

If they are facing this issue and they do not hear from the Minister who has sectorial overview of this very important sector, then I think we will not be doing this country any good. So, in programming the Business for the next week, we thought the Business Committee, led by Hon Mahama Ayariga, who is pretending to not listen to me, should have programmed the Minister for Finance to appear before the House. I do not know what Mr Ayariga went to do at the Business Committee meeting. The Minister for Finance must come to brief us about the suffering of the one million cocoa farmers in this country. What is Hon Ayariga doing? Thank you very much Mr Speaker.

Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I would like to draw your attention to Order 216 (2) (a) and Order 216 (3). Order 216 (2) (a) says that,

Subject to Order 67, the Committee shall

- (a) propose the business of each Sitting and the order in which the business is taken, except that the House may determine which matters may properly be introduced in the House at any time.

Order 216 (3) also says that,

“The power of the Committee in rule (2)(a) shall not limit the power of the Speaker to propose which matters may be introduced in the House.”.

Mr Speaker, it is within your mandate that in instances where the Business Committee even fails to table a matter for discussion, when the matter is of public importance and you also believe same — I am proposing that this cocoa matter is a serious matter that I am calling on you, Mr Speaker, to respectfully call on the Business Committee —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you know the rules, that when a matter has been raised on the same day by two Members who spoke earlier, you do not repeat same.

Mr Assafuah: Respectfully, you said that he cannot raise that matter at the time that he raised it, and that he was supposed to have made it at the time that Statements were made. I am drawing your attention —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, how different is what you are saying from what Hon Habib and Hon Boamah have said? You know that you cannot direct me on how the discretion of a Speaker is supposed to be exercised.

Mr Assafuah: Respectfully, I am not doing that. I am just praying you. I am just making an application to you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, I am asking you a question; how different is what you are saying from what has been raised by Hon Habib and Hon Patrick Yaw Boamah, drawing the attention of the Leader of Government Business and the Chairperson of the Business Committee to it?

Mr Assafuah: I am also saying that when the two people —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You are sounding repetitive, so kindly resume your seats?

Mr Assafuah: No, hold on. I have two other concerns. My next concern is that yesterday, right here on this Floor, I drew your attention to the fact that I have brought the Minister of State in charge of Government Communications to come here to answer to Questions. I was

expecting that on the *Order Paper* for today, it would have been mentioned, but it was not mentioned.

In fact, I have also gone through the whole of the Business Statement and the question has also not been stated in the ensuing week. So, I do not know when the Minister of State in charge of Government Communications will come here.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I am not supposed to ask you questions, but you know the rules regarding admission and processing of a Question. So, when Questions are admitted and transmitted to the Table Office, and the admission includes your Question, and your question has not been captured, what do you do? Kindly resume your seats.

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, I have a third concern.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: With all due respect.

Mr Assafuah: You said I should not speak about that. I have a third concern.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let me hear your third concern.

Mr Assafuah: My third concern is that last week, I was on this Floor, and I drew your attention to the fact that we wrote a Motion and made an application to the Speaker about the fact that there were tendencies of Lesbians, Gay, Bisexual, Transgender, Queer (LGBTQ) content that have been found

in our teacher manuals. In that application, the Rt Hon Speaker referred the matter to the Committee on Education. In fact, we followed up with a memorandum.

As we speak, 10 days down the line, per the Standing Orders, the Committee has three months to report back to the House. In the circumstances, we have to draw in all stakeholders who are involved, like teachers, the Ministry of Education, the Ghana Education Service, Transforming Teaching Education & Learning (TTEL) and National Council for Curriculum and Assessment (NaCCA). It is going to be a long process. If the Committee on Education, as we speak, has not even scheduled for us to be able to take this matter, it is worrisome. I was expecting that the Business Committee and the Chairperson would make sure that it is in the Business Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I am sorry to say this, you are a well-respected lawyer. You have also indicated that by the Rules, the Committee has three months to work. If 10 days along the line, you have not heard anything from the Committee, there are remedial measures that you can take. It is not for you to come to the Floor to say it without taking those remedial measures. What do you want this Floor to do for you? It is entirely in your domain to follow the remedial measures. That is why I indicated clearly that when the procedure is set down for a right to be exercised, you must follow the procedure in exercising your rights and that is what I expected you as a lawyer who is also a

Member of Parliament to do. Yes, Dr Kabiru?

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I would want to also note with appreciation the work of the Business Committee in rolling out the Business for the ensuing week. Mr Speaker, it is an over flogged issue, but I still think that you should consider it, and I will join in appealing to you to consider the request by the Leader of our Side.

Mr Speaker, there is a Statement that has been admitted in my name, and I want to thank them because it was an issue I raised last week. Once they have captured it and have taken into consideration that particular Statement, I want to commend them. When the Leader of the House was responding to questions last week, he did not respond to that question, so I was worried. But having found it in the Business Statement, I think it is well-recommended.

Mr Speaker, I have observed one thing. It appears to me that the Majority Side is now asking more Questions than the Minority Side. Mr Speaker, they are in Government, so I expect them to have their issues addressed by the Government. But they now resort to asking Questions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, we are guided by rules. Show me the rule that indicates that it is only the Minority Side that is supposed to ask Questions. Please, go by the rules. If you

do not have anything in the rules to do so, kindly take your seat.

Dr A. K. T. Mahama: I am making a harmless observation. I defer to you that the rules actually allow both Sides to ask Questions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then please resume your seat. Leadership of the Minority?

Ms Patricia Appiagyei: Thank you, Mr Speaker. On page 1 of the Business Statement, I have noticed that there is a Statement that is being made by Hon Dorcas Toffey. If my memory serves me right, on Wednesday, there was a presentation of such a Statement from one of us.

I was wondering if it is proper to admit the Statement of the same nature at this point? So, I want to appeal to the Leader of the House to take that Statement out. I do not understand why we should repeat that Statement, because a number of people have presented Statements on different topics. I am talking about the Statement by Hon Dorcas Toffey on page 1. I think that was done by Hon Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe, and we discussed it. So, I do not know why we are repeating the same Statement, or a similar one.

Thank you.

3:26 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, that is a very good observation. I will then move to Hon Peter Nortsu-Kotoe, and

give the floor to the Majority Leader, then we will draw the curtains.

Mr Peter Kwasi Nortsu-Kotoe: Mr Speaker, Hon Assafuah made an allusion to the Committee on Education that a reference was made to us, for which the Committee had not acted upon. Yes, we have received the memo from the Deputy Minority Leader. I have spoken with the Ranking Member, but the issue is that we cannot meet without the Minority Leader, who is the petitioner. So, our inability to meet is because the Minority Leader is not available.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I believe strongly that this information could have been made available to him if he had used the rules and the remedial measures available to him. He would have known the challenge the Committee is facing. The Committee has a Chairperson and a Ranking Member.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, there was a question about Hon Members of the Majority Side asking Questions, and you rightly responded. We encourage everybody to ask Questions. Their constituents should hear them ask Questions. I believe that, whether in Government or out of Government, every Member of Parliament here is entitled to ask Questions, and when they ask, the Ministers are obliged to come and answer.

The Minister of State in charge of Government Communications and the Questions that he is supposed to answer, I assure Hon Members that I will follow up and make sure that those Questions are re-listed, so that the Minister will come and answer them. The issue of our repeating Statements on gender violence, we addressed that. The Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, Transgender, and Queer (LGBTQ) curricula probe request, as indicated by the Speaker, there are rules governing how we get things done in this House. So, if a Member has an issue, they go through those rules, raise them, and then we will address them.

On the issue of cocoa, I believe the Minister has addressed cocoa farmers. Maybe they want him to address Members of Parliament; we can have that discussion with the Minister and see the earliest possible convenient time when he can come and then address Members of Parliament. I can assure Members that cocoa farmers have been spoken to directly by the Minister, and the farmers understand the situation, and it is unpleasant, but cocoa farmers understand the situation. I listened to radio this morning, and the various leaders of the Cocoa Farmer Associations, several of them spoke on radio and indicated that in view of the declining world market price of the commodity, they themselves as farmers, they themselves as farmers know that it will be difficult to get exactly the amount that they were initially promised.

So, I believe that the farmers understand, and they are very excited about the long-term measures that

Government is putting in place to address systemically the challenges in the cocoa sector. I recall that in this House, time and again, we have raised the issue of cocoa roads and how that has encumbered and burdened the cocoa farmer. As we heard from the Minister for Finance yesterday, all the debt is taken away and transferred to the Minister for Roads and Highways. Therefore, the Ministry of Finance will pay that, and then we will restructure the Ghana Cocoa Board (COCOBOD) and make sure that it is a more efficient and effective organisation. We will also introduce financing mechanisms that will allow people to buy into the cocoa sector and then finance the purchase of cocoa beans.

We also have a major policy shift in the area of having a percentage of cocoa that must be processed in Ghana. That will also tie in with job creation and then the expansion of the manufacturing sector in our economy. So, it is not just about dealing with the current crisis, but looking into the future and finding a solution that addresses systemically and long-term the challenges of the cocoa sector. But the Minister will come. I will try to convince him to come, then we can all engage in this conversation. It is a national issue, and we represent constituents who are in the cocoa sector.

They may think that we do not grow cocoa in Bawku, but if we go to the entire country where cocoa is grown, we will find out that many of the farmers there, many of the owners of the small farms, are from my Constituency. So, I can assure Members that Bawku is as

interested in cocoa price as any other Member of Parliament from any of the southern regions here. I am a stakeholder in the cocoa industry. That, I can say in confidence. So, the Minister will definitely come so that he can brief us as well on the measures that the Government is taking.

I do agree that it is important. But we needed to respond to the farmers first, and then put them at ease, and come to the House and engage the Leaders who are in the House.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, once I have taken the Leadership, you know I will not have such a reverse gear. Hon Members, the Business Statement as presented is hereby adopted.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, who is also acting as the Minister for Environment, Science and Technology, which Ministry does not have a deputy, is available to answer Questions. Mr Speaker, the Minister was in South Africa, and I called him to come from South Africa and answer the Questions. This is how serious this Minister is about his job. He was in South Africa attending the Indaba Conference, which is an annual mining conference. Indeed, he was the toast of the Conference. He is a Minister with a Deputy, who is not the Deputy Minister

for Environment, Science, and Technology?

So, Mr Speaker, we will take the Questions.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I heard somewhere that the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources and the oversight on the Ministry for Environment, Science and Technology came back to Accra on a chartered flight. Is it the case?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, Hon Boamah is his witness; they flew in together. He says that Hon Boamah chartered the flight, and he joined him—
[Laughter]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, once Hon Boamah is a living witness, tell us how you came to the country. [Uproar] Did you come into the country by chartered flight?

3:36 p.m.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think we should lay some two documents before the Questions are taken. Item number 10 (a) (i) and (ii). So, Mr Speaker, I crave your indulgence to vary the order of Business and lay those Papers, then come back to Questions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leadership, the application is to vary the order of Business to take the item numbered 10.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, we do not have any difficulty with that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, at Commencement of Public Business, Presentation of Papers. Item number 10 (a), by the Minister for Energy and Green Transition.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources bowed from where he is seated and it is unacceptable. There was no application for the Deputy Minister to do it on behalf of the Minister, and he is not the Minister; he is the Deputy Minister. Is it the case that he wants to overthrow his boss? (To be expunged on the order of Mr Speaker)

An Hon Member: Oh! How?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib Iddrisu, I think when we make statements on the Floor, we want the general public to take us seriously. I have presided over the House over and over, and we indicated and placed on the record that if the Minister is not available and the Minister has a Deputy, the Deputy must be here to do the Business for and on behalf of the Minister. So, the fact that the Deputy Minister is here in that capacity to lay the Papers does not mean he is making an attempt to overthrow his Minister. We say some things as jokes, but it goes into the record.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, not to belittle their point. The *Order Paper* says, by the Minister for Energy and Green Transition. Mr Speaker, I agree that the Deputy Minister under our Orders can do so on behalf of the Minister, but it is not automatic.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You see, I am worried about what you are placing on the record, whether the Deputy Minister is trying to overthrow the Minister—

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, he should withdraw the statement about overthrowing—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Because these things are going into the record. It is going into the *Hansard*.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the Hon Majority Leader is a very good lawyer. I said, “Is it the case that he wants to overthrow his Minister?” I did not say he wants to overthrow his Minister. It is a question.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I want to make an application for the Minister—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the statement that “Is it the case that the Deputy Minister for Energy and Green Transition is trying to

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, overthrow his Minister” is accordingly ordered to be expunged from the records.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the Minister is not available immediately, so if we can have the Deputy Minister lay the Paper on behalf of the Minister.

the application is for the Deputy Minister to present the Papers on behalf of the Minister.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, we do not have any difficulty with that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Deputy Minister, you may do so for and on behalf of the Minister.

PAPERS

By the Deputy Minister for Energy and Green Transition (Mr Richard Gyan Mensah) on behalf of the Minister for Energy and Green Transition—

- (i) Amendment for the extension of the Terms of the West Cape Three Point Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation, GNPC Exploration and Production Limited Company, Tullow Ghana Limited, Kosmos Energy Ghana HC, Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments and Petrosa Ghana Limited.
- (ii) Amendment for the extension of the Terms of the Deepwater Tano Petroleum Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation, GNPC Exploration and Production Limited Company, Tullow Ghana Limited, Kosmos Energy Ghana HC, Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments and Petrosa Ghana Limited

Referred to the Committee on Energy.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, we will turn to page 6 of the *Order Paper* for the Chairperson for the Committee on Energy is here to lay three Reports. So, we will take item number 10 (b) (iii), (iv), and (v). The Chairperson is here to lay the Reports.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, starting from the item numbered 10 (b).

Mr R. Acheampong: He is laying (b) (iii), (iv), and (v). They are laying their Reports.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Item numbered 10 (b) (i), (ii), (iii), (iv), and (v) by the Chairperson of the Committee on Energy.

Hon Members, let us lay all of them together since they are by the same Chairperson.

By the Chairperson of the Committee—

- (i) Report of the Committee on Energy on the Amendment for the extension of the Terms of the West Cape Three Point Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation, GNPC Exploration and Production

Limited Company, Tullow Ghana Limited, Kosmos Energy Ghana HC, Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments and Petrosa Ghana Limited.

- (ii) Report of the Committee on Energy on the Amendment for the extension of the Terms of the Deepwater Tano Petroleum Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation, GNPC Exploration and Production Limited Company, Tullow Ghana Limited, Kosmos Energy Ghana HC, Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments and Petrosa Ghana Limited.
- (iii) Report of the Committee on Energy on the Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ghana National Gas Company Limited for the year 2024.
- (iv) Report of the Committee on Energy on the Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company Limited for the year 2024.
- (v) Report of the Committee on Energy on the Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Tema Oil Refinery for the year 2024.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Reports numbered 10 (b) (i), (ii), (iii), (iv), and (v) at page 5 and 6 of today's *Order Paper* have all been duly presented to the House and it is for distribution to Hon Members.

Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr R. Acheampong: Mr Speaker, we will now turn to item number 8 of today's *Order Paper* at page 3 for the Minister to answer the Urgent Questions and the subsequent Questions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Acting Minister for Environment, Science and Technology has been scheduled to answer designated Questions, some Urgent Questions, others Oral Questions. The Minister is already seated to answer those Questions. I will therefore proceed to give the floor to the Member questioners to do so.

3:46 p.m.

The Urgent Question is standing in the name of Ms Shirley Kyei, Hon Member for Atwima Nwabiagya South.

Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah: Mr Speaker, I rise on Order 88(3), which states that

“In the absence of the Member, any other Member so authorised may, with the prior permission of the Speaker, ask the Question.”

Mr Speaker, I have the authority of Hon Shirley Kyei to ask the Question on her behalf.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please do.

URGENT QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF ENVIRONMENT,
SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY

The Scale Up, Marketing and Distribution of Newly Introduced Food Products

Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah on behalf of Ms Shirley Kyei (NPP — Atwima Nwabiagya South): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Environment, Science and Technology how the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR) intend to scale up the marketing and distribution of its newly introduced food products and to support food security and small Agro-Processors.

Minister for Environment, Science and Technology (Mr Emmanuel Armah-Kofi Buah) (MP): Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

The Council for Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR) is mandated under the CSIR Act 1996, Act 521, to conduct scientific research and commercialise its research outputs. In fulfilment of this mandate, CSIR has developed demand-driven technologies, innovations, products and services that meet market needs and enhance agricultural production, agro-processing and food preservation. These technologies and products are designed to respond to the needs of agro-processors, private businesses,

consumers and industry players. To strengthen commercialisation efforts, CSIR has revamped its commercialisation directorate to actively drive the market uptake of research outputs on a full-time commercial basis.

The directorate focuses on three priorities: developing and implementing effective marketing strategies; engaging industry and private-sector partners to facilitate commercialisation and technology transfer; and building institutional capacity in marketing, business development, and industry engagement across all 13 CSIR institutes. This institutional restructuring enhances CSIR's capacity to transition innovations from laboratory development to market deployment. To address the challenge of demand-exceeding supply of CSIR's commercial products, the Council actively pursues partnerships with commercial players, SMEs and agro-processes to upscale production, strengthen distribution channels, expand market access and integrate key value chain actors, including farmers, processors and marketers.

Beyond direct commercialisation, CSIR institutes enter into MOUs with private farms and industry players to scale agricultural production and embed research outputs into commercial operations. In addition, CSIR delivers capacity-building and training programmes in small-scale research-based processing, post-harvest handling, food safety standards, product development and packaging, and technical guidance on scaling up

production to support sustainable enterprise growth and job creation. Currently, the Council is expanding the partnership with private sector actors to support off-take arrangements and the scaling up of research outputs.

CSIR also organises platforms such as food fairs and participates in exhibitions, open days, and related events to showcase technologies and products to prospective investors, agro-processors, entrepreneurs, and policymakers. These initiatives enhance visibility, stimulate investment, create business linkages and strengthen agro-processing value chains, thereby contributing to national food and nutritional security.

I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary questions?

Mr Assafuah: Let me thank the Hon Minister for his answer. What are some of the specific products that CSIR targets to scale up?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, as I stated, CSIR has really created a commercialisation department, and the focus is to drive the market on a full-time basis to meet the demand of the market. We are also engaging in the private sector. Examples of products like *prekese* syrup and what they call, for example, Pro-Gari are all products that have been promoted and have been commercialised.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further supplementary?

Hon Members, that brings us to the end of Urgent Questions. We then come to Oral Questions numbered 501, standing in the name of Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh, Member of Parliament for Nsawam/Adoagyiri.

You have the floor.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF ENVIRONMENT, SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY

Enforcement of the Bilateral Agreement between Ghana and Singapore

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu *on behalf of Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh (NPP — Nsawam-Adoagyiri)*: Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Environment, Science and Technology, the extent of enforcement and adherence to the bilateral agreement between Ghana and Singapore pursuant to Article 6 of the Paris Agreement and what benefits we can boast of today since its coming into force.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, the Ghana-Singapore Bilateral Agreement Offers Exciting Opportunities for Ghana, and there are many benefits Ghana can enjoy from this Partnership. The Republic of Ghana and the Republic of Singapore signed an Implementation Agreement (IA) under Article 6.2 of the Paris Agreement on 27th May, 2024.

Subsequently, the Joint Committee (JC) with representation from Ghana (Ministry of Environment, Science and Technology and the Environmental Protection Authority) and Singapore's Ministry of Trade and Industry and the National Environment Agency, established under the Implementation Agreement, was inaugurated, leading to the launch of a call for carbon market project applications.

Currently, 39 project ideas have been submitted to both Governments by local and international project developers. The pipeline projects include renewable energy such as solar PV, biodiesel production, and clean cooking technologies (charcoal, ethanol, electric, and ethanol stoves); e-vehicles (cars and bikes); electric car charging stations; afforestation and conservation; mangrove restoration; and water treatment and biochar.

Mr Speaker, following the submissions of the initial project proposals, 24 applications by the Joint Committee have received no-objection approvals in the form of Letters of Intent from Ghana and Letters of Support from the Singapore side, allowing them to move beyond the concept stage.

The Ghana-Singapore Implementation Agreement (IA) is assisting the private sector in implementing green projects to help Ghana achieve its Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs) and contribute to the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). Ghana aims to use this IA to achieve its budget of 24 million tonnes

of carbon dioxide equivalent (CO₂e) available for market transactions under the current phase of the NDCs. Although the Agreement supports projects that reduce greenhouse gas emissions, it also aims to improve public health, expand access to financial services, and provide other benefits.

The IA will provide access to technology that otherwise could not have been possible due to barriers, including financial and market barriers. Furthermore, revenues from carbon credit sales (ITMOs) can be reinvested into local projects. For instance, similar Article 6.2 initiatives in Ghana, such as the Switzerland Bilateral Agreement, have led to investment decisions totalling more than 850 million United States Dollars (US\$850m), yielding benefits for communities and beneficiaries, as well as for the value chain (project developers and financial institutions, including local banks). The IA aims to create 1,500 green jobs for youth and increase Ghanaian participation in this niche market.

Mr Speaker, since the implementation of the Ghana-Singapore agreement started, the following have been achieved. 139 project ideas have been submitted to the Ministry, including renewable energy, solar PV, biodiesel, clean cooking technologies, e-vehicles, charging stations, afforestation, mangrove restoration, and water treatment. A joint committee has been established to review and issue 24 no-objection approvals from both governments.

Four projects on water treatment and improved cook stoves have reached a decision point on government authorisation. The projects are expected to provide access to clean water and improve the cooking experience in rural Ghana, while also attracting capital investment, generating carbon revenue for project owners, and generating government fees. For the remaining 20 projects, the developers have submitted their concept notes and are currently under review.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, any supplementary question?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: No supplementary question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We then move to Question numbered 502, also standing in the name of Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh.

Ghanaians Employed by the EPA in the Past Three Months

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu on behalf of Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh (NPP — Nsawam-Adoagyiri): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Environment, Science and Technology how many Ghanaians the Environmental Protection Authority (EPA) has employed in the past three months, the categories of officers employed, and if financial clearance was obtained from the Ministry of Finance for such employment within the period mentioned.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, since January 2025, the Environmental Protection Authority (EPA) has operated under an expanded mandate covering environmental protection, regulation, coordination, and climate change oversight. In response to the increased scope of work and persistent environmental degradation, the need to expand EPA operations to the district and municipal levels, particularly through increased field staffing, was formally recognised in the 2023/2024 Parliamentary Public Accounts Committee deliberations on the Auditor-General's Report.

Accordingly, the EPA requested recruitment clearance from the Ministry of Finance on 8th August, 2025 and issued contract appointments to support immediate operational needs. Towards the end of the year 2025, the Authority received approval to recruit 500 permanent staff, enabling the regularisation of some contract personnel, and will continue to seek additional recruitment clearance in 2026.

Since November 2025, the EPA has recruited 392 contract staff, made up of technical staff 295 and administrative staff 97 to support immediate operational needs. The authority has received clearance from the Ministry of Finance to recruit 500 permanent staff to enable the regularisation of the contract personnel.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, any supplementary? Hon Member, I have always stated that when a Member exhausts or says they do not have a

supplementary question, before another Member can have the opportunity.

Yes, any supplementary?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I do not have any supplementary questions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Yes, Hon Jerry Shaib?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, the Minister in his response indicated that the first batch, which is about 350, are contract staff. Does that mean that they did not have clearance before they were recruited?

3:56 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, in response to the increased scope of work and persistent environmental degradation and the need to expand EPA operations to the district and municipal levels, particularly through increased field staffing, indeed, those actions were taken and contract staff were employed. Coincidentally, I am very happy to report that we have received clearance for the Ministry to basically regularise those contract staff.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I do not think the Hon Minister got my question, but I do not want to belabour the point.

So, it is fine. I do not want to ask any further questions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to the Question numbered 282, standing in the name of Dr Isaac Yaw Opoku, Member of Parliament for Offinso South.

Measures to Ensure that Research Findings from Research Institutions are not Wasted

Dr Isaac Yaw Opoku (NPP — Offinso South): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Environment, Science and Technology the measures the Ministry is taking to ensure that important research findings from the various research institutions do not go to waste.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Buah: The Ministry has taken deliberate steps to ensure that critical research outputs are effectively utilised. One activity that was promoted by the immediate past Minister was a proposal to hold a bi-annual Environment, Science and Technology Best Forum to connect research to industry and promote technology transfer and diffusion.

The first Best Forum was held at the La Palm Royal Beach Hotel during the last quarter of 2025. Beyond this, the Ministry is reinforcing its coordination role by mobilising funding for applied research, supporting development and technology transfer activities, and

formulating policies that incentivise private sector participation. Significantly, the Ministry is also prioritising the mobilisation of domestic and development partners' funding for research aligned with national priorities, knowing that over-reliance on donor funding often shifts research focus toward donor interest rather than the Ghanaian interest.

So, Mr Speaker, the Ministry is also steadfastly bridging the gap between research from Ghana's research institutions and transformative national applications, ensuring no innovation goes to waste in our collective march toward prosperity. Through the Ghana Research and Industry Collaborative Grid, we bring together research, academia, industry, government, and global partners in building research databases, reformatting projects for market readiness, and forging commercialisation pathways via annual stakeholder fora that unite partnerships for economic leapfrogging.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Environment, Science and Technology recognises the essential role that research and innovation play in national development. Indeed, research findings from institutions such as the Council for Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR) have enormous potential to address socio-economic and environmental challenges and to support Ghana's industrial transformation agenda.

In response to the implementation of research outputs, His Excellency the

President has instructed my Ministry to develop a comprehensive Policy on Commercialising Research and Innovation to provide a framework for the exploitation of research outputs through Patenting, Licensing and Public-Private Ventures.

Mr Speaker, to ensure that research findings do not go to waste, the Ministry is implementing the following specific measures:

- a) Facilitating stronger collaboration between research institutions, policymakers, and industry to ensure that research outputs are demand-driven, market-relevant, and easily translatable into practical solutions, technologies, and products. Mechanisms such as stakeholder platforms, joint forums, and innovation challenges are being promoted to enhance uptake.
- b) Research institutions under the Ministry, including CSIR, have been encouraged to develop and implement research uptake plans. These plans involve the packaging of research findings in user-friendly formats for different stakeholders, including farmers, entrepreneurs, investors, and government agencies.
- c) Under initiatives like the Science Granting Councils Initiative (SGCI), the Ministry is funding research that is co-designed with end-users, ensuring relevance and uptake. Research themes often

align with national priorities such as climate change adaptation, food security, public health, and clean energy.

- d) The Ministry is also implementing the African Knowledge and Technology Transfer Partnership Project under the UK-Ghana STI Strategy. This model only funds collaborative research projects between research and knowledge institutions and business establishments where the outputs of research must be addressing specific demands of a business.
- e) The Ministry is supporting the development of digital repositories and knowledge portals to make research findings accessible to a wider audience, including policy actors, innovators, students, and the media. This is in line with steps in advancing a comprehensive open science strategy in alignment with UNESCO's 2021 Recommendation on Open Science and Ghana's STI4SDG Road Map.
- f) The Ministry continues to advocate for increased investment in research utilisation across sectors. Ongoing reforms in science, technology and innovation governance, including the operationalisation of the National STI Policy and Implementation Plan, are helping to institutionalise research uptake as a key outcome of government-funded research.

g) The Ministry successfully hosted the African Research Initiative for Scientific Excellence (ARISE) High Level Meeting in Accra from 3rd– 4th July, 2025. ARISE represents a compelling vision to catalyse scientific excellence in Africa by nurturing the next generation of researchers, promoting research collaboration, and embedding science within the fabric of national and continental development agendas. The meeting was opened by the President of the Republic, H.E. John Dramani Mahama and closed by the Vice President, H.E. Prof. Naana Jane Opoku-Agyemang. ARISE brought together policy actors, researchers, academia to commit to advancing Africa's research through investment, capacity building initiatives and a call to action for global science diplomacy. An Accra declaration was adopted as a key outcome of the two-day high-level meeting which serves as a blueprint for research and innovation transformation in line with the aspirations of the SDGs, AU Agenda 2063 and STISA 2024/2034. His Excellency the President announced a GHC10.3 million (USD\$1 million) support to ARISE as contribution of the government of the Republic of Ghana in support of Africa research and innovation.

h) As part of efforts to promote science-policy-society linkages, the Ministry has established the

Biannual Environment, Science and Technology (BEST) Forum, which is a platform for researchers, scientists, innovators, and industry professionals to interact and exchange ideas related to environmental, scientific, and technological advancements. The forum aims to promote innovation, provide networking opportunities, and raise awareness about the importance of Science, Technology, and Innovation (STI) for national development.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary question?

Dr I. Y. Opoku: Mr Speaker, I want to find out from the Hon Minister whether he would consider bringing the important stakeholders together, the research institutions and the entrepreneurs for a common workshop or exhibition for them to see if they —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, you can suggest that to the Minister.

Hon Minister, kindly resume your seat? Do you have any further supplementary question?

Dr I. Y. Opoku: No, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let us take the Question numbered 283, also standing in the name of Dr Opoku.

Measures to Protect the Coastal and Marine Environment from Plastic Pollution

Dr Isaac Yaw Opoku (NPP — Offinso South): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask Minister for Environment, Science and Technology the measures the Ministry is implementing to protect the coastal and marine environment from plastic pollution.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Buah: The Ministry, together with the EPA, is implementing an integrated approach of policy regulatory and investment-driven interventions to protect Ghana's coastal and marine environment from plastic pollution while also regulating plastic production and promoting sustainable alternatives. The implementation of the national plastic management policy is ensuring the enforcement of environmental standards governing plastic production, importation, use and disposal.

In aligning with global and regional policies for the management of plastics, the Ministry and EPA are enacting the extended producer responsibility EPA legislation to ensure that producers and importers finance the collection, recovery and environmentally sound management of plastic waste investment and programmes such as the World Bank funded WACA programme, which is supporting coastal resilience, marine pollution control and improved solid

waste management in coastal municipalities.

Again, the Pro Blue Trust Fund, a component of WACA, is specifically supporting marine litter and plastic pollution reduction, policy reform, institutional strengthening and circular economy solutions linked to ocean health.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry is implementing an integrated approach of policy, regulatory and investment-driven interventions to protect Ghana's coastal and marine environment from plastic pollution, while also regulating plastic production and promoting sustainable alternatives.

The Ministry together with its agencies is implementing the National Plastics Management Policy, enforcing environmental standards governing plastic production, importation, use, and disposal; and enacting Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) legislation to ensure that producers and importers finance the collection, recovery, and environmentally sound management of plastic waste.

Mr Speaker, below are some specific interventions and initiatives being pursued by the Ministry:

Waste Management Infrastructure

The Ministry is in the process of constructing plastics buy-back centres and plastics collection points in coastal areas, with the first pilot designated for Jamestown. This initiative is under the

proposed construction of a Central Waste Sorting Centre, a sorting facility that will allow for the separation of recyclable plastics from general waste.

This promotes recycling, reduces landfill pressure, and minimises the amount of plastic waste that could leak into the marine environment. Additionally, dedicated collection centres make it easier for communities to dispose of plastic waste responsibly, increase plastic recovery rates, and reduce the likelihood of plastics entering waterways.

Distribution of dustbins to households and commercial centers

As part of efforts to promote proper disposal of waste, colour-coded bins would be distributed to households and commercial centres to improve waste segregation and collection. This encourages proper waste disposal at the source, reducing littering and illegal dumping, preventing plastics from being washed into drains and eventually reaching the ocean. Educational campaigns will also be launched to educate recipients on the use of bins.

Equipment and Tools for Waste Workers

The Ministry will procure and distribute tricycles, wheelbarrows, plastic trash pickers, and PPEs for plastic waste workers, enabling better access to hard-to-reach areas and safer operations. This helps intercept waste before it enters the sea and improves the efficiency of collection.

Policy and Governance

Mr Speaker, as part of Government policy interventions to address the plastic menace especially in the coastal areas, the Ministry will implement an Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) system and an electronic registry (E Registry) for Plastics. This initiative aims to hold producers accountable for the entire lifecycle of their products, including post-consumer waste. This incentivises eco-friendly packaging and ensures that producers contribute to waste management efforts.

A technical committee will be established to guide the development of regulations and the creation of an electronic registry for plastics and intensive engagements with the relevant stakeholders such as plastic manufacturers and importers will be undertaken.

In addition, the Ministry will create awareness on the National Plastics Management Policy and facilitate the development of local action plans as well as promote policy adoption through workshops and training sessions. This would ensure coordinated action across sectors to tackle plastic pollution. MMDCEs would be supported in developing local action plans to implement the policy at the community level, ensuring relevance and effectiveness.

Behavioural and Community-Based Interventions

Mr Speaker, the Ministry will launch a campaign to retrieve old fishing nets along the entire coastline of Ghana, aiming to reduce ghost fishing, ghost

gear pollution, and entanglement hazards in coastal areas.

The Ministry also aims to promote research into alternative packaging and its adoption. The introduction of biodegradable or reusable alternatives to plastic packaging will reduce dependency on single-use plastics. These behavioural change interventions are crucial in coastal communities where plastic waste often ends up in the ocean.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry expects these combined interventions to result in a measurable reduction in plastic waste entering rivers, lagoons, and the marine environment, and also enhanced protection of marine biodiversity, fisheries, tourism assets, and coastal livelihoods.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary questions?

Dr I. Y. Opoku: Mr Speaker, I want to ask the Hon Minister if there is any system in place to measure the success of the implementation strategies.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, as part of the measures that I described, there are clear measures embedded in these measures to make sure that we can measure the progress we are making and whether or not we are being successful in the drawbacks. So, these are part of the WACA project. There are measures being taken to ensure that we make progress.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any other question?

Dr I. Y. Opoku: No, Mr Speaker

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, let us move now to the Question numbered 334, standing in the name of Hon Gloria Owusu.

Mr Frederick Addy (NPP — Suaman): Mr Speaker, I rise under Order 88(3). I have the authority of the Hon Member—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please do.

Mr Addy: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Timelines and Expected Amendments in the Review of the Biosafety Act 2021-2025 and its incorporation of new Global Biosecurity Standards

Mr Frederick Addy on behalf of Ms Gloria Owusu (NPP — Trobu): To ask the Minister for Environment, Science and Technology, the timelines and expected amendments in the review of the Biosafety Act 2021-2025 and how the review will incorporate new global biosecurity standards.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, the National Biosafety Authority's (NBA) current focus on biosafety is necessary but not sufficient to address Ghana's biosecurity needs comprehensively. Expanding NBA's mandate to include a One Health

approach, strengthening biosecurity protocols, and fostering intersectoral collaboration are essential steps to enhance national biosecurity readiness.

The amendment of the Biosafety Act, 2011 (Act 831) is driven by the need to:

- To expand scope of the NBA's regulation to include biosafety and biosecurity during the development, handling, and use of both non-GMO and GMO biologicals and biosimilar.

- To strengthen current biosafety regulation of GMOs (across agriculture, healthcare, and industrial applications) by addressing any gaps and future proof the legislation for emerging technologies.

Key Areas Proposed by Stakeholders for Amendment of Act 831

The table below provides proposed areas for amendment of Biosafety Act 2011, Act 831.

Provisions of the Act	Recommended Amendment (Stakeholder recommendation and NBA's future direction)
Preamble and Scope (Sections 1–2) 1. Scope 2. Objectives	Amend the title, scope, and objectives of Act 831 to expand regulation beyond GMOs to include biosafety and biosecurity for all biological agents, biological products, biosimilars, pathogens, toxins, and emerging biological materials across all sectors. The amended Act should explicitly reflect the national need to manage risks associated with both GMO and non-GMO biological materials in line with international conventions such as the Cartagena protocol on biosafety, Biological warfare convention, UN Resolution 1540 etc.
Section 2 — Application of the Act	Expand the application of the Act to reflect the expanded scope above, and to include containment facilities in research, diagnostics, manufacturing (food and pharma), healthcare, and other industrial applications of biological agents products. Ensure the Authority can exercise oversight over the development, handling, transport, and use of all biologicals to safeguard public health, environmental safety, and national security.
//Biosecurity and Dual-Use Provisions	Introduce stand-alone provisions addressing biosecurity, dual-use research, intentional misuse, unauthorised possession, theft, diversion, or release of biological agents, pathogens, toxins, and dangerous biological materials. Ensure alignment with international best practice and global security frameworks.

4:06 p.m.

Biosecurity and Dual-Use Provisions	Introduce stand-alone provisions addressing biosecurity, dual-use research, intentional misuse, unauthorised possession, theft, diversion, or release of biological agents, pathogens, toxins, and dangerous biological materials. Ensure alignment with international best practice and global security frameworks.	
Functions of the Authority (Section 4)	Expand the Authority's functions to cover biosafety and biosecurity oversight across research, diagnostic, industrial, pharmaceutical, and healthcare sectors. This should include powers for monitoring biological handling environments, conducting inspections, undertaking risk assessments, managing import and export controls of biological materials, and coordinating national preparedness and response for biological risks.	
Sections 31–32 (Regulatory Agencies)	Strengthen collaboration between the NBA and other agencies that play key roles in biosecurity, public health, and national security. Define mechanisms for i) inter-agency coordination to avoid conflict and duplication, and ii) emergency response to safeguard public health and environment.	
Section 33 — Appointment of Inspectors	Revise Section 33 to allow the Authority as part of its continuous professional development train its technical staff as inspectors through its own established institutional processes. This will remove the requirement for lengthy appointment procedures and strengthen operational responsiveness.	
Emerging Technologies	Future-proof the Act such that new and emerging technologies would be catered for without the need to constantly revise the Act. Include explicit regulatory provisions for new and rapidly evolving technologies such as gene drives, synthetic biology etc.	
Offences and Penalties	Strengthen offences and penalties to address administrative breaches, unauthorised possession, handling, transfer, use, or movement of GMOs, biological agents, pathogens, toxins, or dual-use materials. Introduce sanctions proportionate to the public health and national security risks posed by non-compliance.	
Section 44 — Interpretation	Update and expand definitions to reflect modern biotechnology, biosafety, and biosecurity terminology, including: “biologicals,” “biosimilars,” “biological agents,”	

(Terminology Updates)	“biosecurity,” “dual-use biological material,” “emerging technologies,” “gene editing,” “gene drives,” and “synthetic biology.” Ensure definitions are harmonized with international standards to improve clarity and regulatory consistency.
Recommendation on Structure of the Act	For clarity and operational efficiency, reorganize the Act into the following parts: 1. Administration and Governance 2. GMO Regulation 3. Biosafety and Biosecurity Regulation 4. Import, Export, and Transboundary Movement Controls This structure enhances readability, streamlines implementation, and aligns with the expanded regulatory scope.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry in collaboration with the National Biosafety Authority and relevant stakeholders, will lead the amendment process based on the following indicative timelines:

Timeline	Key Milestone	Status
February - March 2026	Preparation of Cabinet Policy Memorandum.	Ongoing
April - May 2026	Targeted inter-ministerial and agency engagements; Ministries of Health, Finance, Defence and Interior and National Security Secretariat, Ghana Health Service.	Pending
June 2026	Submission of Cabinet Policy Memorandum for Cabinet Approval	Pending
July - September 2026	Drafting of revised legislation by Office of Attorney General and Ministry of Justice.	Pending
October - November 2026	Engagement of selected Parliamentary committees.	Pending
December 2026	Laying of bill in parliament for approval.	Pending

I thank you.

Mr Addy: No, thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary question?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us then move to the

Question numbered 335, standing in the name of Mr Elvis Osei Mensah-Dapaah, Ahafo Ano South West.

Thank you.

Mr Seth Osei-Akoto: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

I rise under Order 88(3) and I have been authorised to ask the Question on behalf of the Questioner.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Measures taken by the Ghana Atomic Energy to Monitor Plantlets and BSF-Based Technologies.

Mr Osei-Akoto on behalf of Mr Elvis Osei Mensah Dapaah (NPP — Ahafo Ano South West): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Environment, Science and Technology, what mechanisms have been taken by the Ghana Atomic Energy Commission (GAEC) to monitor the adoption and use of the 6,000 disease-free plantain plantlets and BSF-based Technologies among farmers.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, I wish to highlight a significant advancement in our agricultural sector that holds promising potential for our farmers and overall food security. The Ghana Atomic Energy Commission (GAEC) has successfully developed specialized plant tissue culture protocols. These protocols

revolutionize our agricultural practices by enabling the mass production of high-quality, disease-free planting materials. This breakthrough technology allows for rapid multiplication and dissemination of clean planting stocks directly to our farmers, ensuring that crops are given the best possible start free from the pathogens often transferred through conventional propagation methods.

Furthermore, the Plant Disease Research Centre at GAEC is fully equipped to rigorously index these planting materials for diseases, guaranteeing quality and safeguarding our agricultural investments. This represents not only a scientific advancement but a strategic opportunity to increase yield, improve farmers' livelihoods, and enhance the resilience of our production systems.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Environment, Science and Technology has played a facilitating role in fostering collaboration between GAEC and key stakeholders such as COCOBOD. This engagement aimed to explore the potential of GAEC supplying disease-free plantain seedlings for the Cocoa Rehabilitation Project, an initiative critical for revitalizing our cocoa sector. Although efforts thus far have not produced concrete outcomes, this potential partnership remains viable and, I would submit, should be vigorously pursued for the mutual benefit of our cocoa farmers and the national economy.

Moreover, the Ministry's support in establishing a dedicated sales point for GAEC's agricultural products, including

seedlings, is a commendable step toward making these high-quality planting materials more accessible to farmers across the nation. Once operational, this platform will serve as a vital outlet for ensuring availability and encouraging adoption.

Looking forward, GAEC is also exploring the establishment of regional out-stations. These sites will serve as crucial dissemination centres for the cutting-edge technologies developed by the Commission's Biotechnology and Nuclear Agriculture Research Institute, thereby deepening the reach and impact of our scientific innovations.

This is a call to recognise and support the integration of science and technology in agriculture. Let us prioritize sustained investment and policy support to bridge the gap between innovation and the hardworking farmer on the ground. Together, we can harness these advancements to accelerate agricultural productivity, ensure food security, and drive sustainable economic growth for Ghana.

Mr Speaker, under the stewardship of the Ghana Atomic Energy Commission's Biotechnology and Nuclear Agriculture Research Institute, we have pioneered revolutionary protocols for mass-producing clean, disease-free planting materials for vital crops like pineapples, plantains, bananas, sweet potatoes and sugarcane, decisively meeting farmers' demands to enhance food security and agriculture productivity across our nation.

I am delighted to announce that the full distribution of 6,000 GAEC-produced plantlets to eager farmers with

fresh stocks in production and strategic alliances with farmer associations and private partners poised to scale volumes, widen market access and deliver the full benefits of biotechnology to our cherished farmers.

Mr Speaker, on the BSF-based technologies, I am delighted to notify this House that GAEC has taken the leadership in Black Star Soldier Fly technology. This is exemplified by the cutting-edge commercial waste processing in the Soldier Fly production facility at Kofi-Sa in the Nsawam /Adoagyiri Municipality.

This facility was built by the International Institute of Tropical Agriculture with Nordic Atlantic Cooperation (NORA) funding and is being used to transform municipal and food industry waste into BSF larvae for premium animal feed and nutrient-packed freeze fertiliser for crop production.

This technology has now reached farmers nationwide, including sensitisation of farmers and agriculture officers in the greater Ahafo Ano and other parts of the country. Through robust demonstration programmes at GAEC and Kofi-Sa facilities, over 300 farmers and agribusiness leaders have been trained and empowered to adopt BSF-based technology for sustainable food production and waste management.

I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary questions?

Mr Osei-Akoto: No, Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this brings us to the end of all the Questions slated for the Minister for Environment, Science and Technology.

On your behalf, I thank the Minister for attending upon the House and responding to the Questions accordingly. The Minister is hereby discharged.

Hon Members, by the Questions slated, the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts is also here to respond to some of the Questions slated for today. I will ask her to take the designated seat. I call on Rev John Ntim Fordjour, Member of Parliament for Assin South, to pose the first Question for the day for the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts.

Ms Shirley Kyei: Mr Speaker, I rise on Order 88(3) and I have the permission of the Member to ask the Question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Ms Shirley, with this one, you do not have the authority.

Ms Kyei: I do.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, if you have the authority, go ahead and ask the Question—[*Laughter*—Because if you have given an authority to somebody to ask a Question on your behalf, and

soon after you walk in, I wonder if that person also has your authority.

Ms Kyei: I was in a meeting and I rushed back.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please ask the Question.

MINISTRY OF TOURISM, CULTURE AND CREATIVE ARTS

Measures the Ministry is Implementing to Prevent Desecration of National Monuments

Ms Shirley Kyei on behalf of Rev John Ntim Fordjour (NPP — Assin South): I beg to ask the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts the measures the Ministry is implementing to prevent the desecration of the Independence Arch, Kwame Nkrumah Mausoleum and other sacred national monuments by same-sex couples and LGBTQ+ activists.

Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts (Ms Abba Dzifa Gomashie) (MP): Mr Speaker, the Ministry recognises the symbolic importance of the Independence Arc, Independence Square, Kwame Nkrumah Memorial Park and other national monuments as focal points for national remembrance and civic celebrations. The Ministry's response to the Question is guided by the; need to preserve the dignity and security of national monuments, rule of law and existing statutory controls over public gatherings and the Ministry's duty to collaborate with the Ministry of National Security,

the Police and the MMDAs and MDAs responsible for public order and safety.

Following the incident in question, the Ministry has taken the following measures.

First, to apply well-defined criteria to assess all requests for use of national monuments under our control. Applicants must present full event details, security plans, and crowd-management strategies. Any proposal that does not meet cultural, security or public order requirements will be rejected.

Second, to enforce existing rules for public gatherings in conformity with statutory instruments, including the Public Order Act, which sets out notification and control mechanisms for special events and routes. The Ministry will ensure that these statutory procedures are strictly applied for any event at all the institutions, facilities or other national monuments under its control.

Mr Speaker, the management of the Independence Square and the Independence Arc is under the control of the Presidential Household at the Office of the President. It is gratifying to note that the National Security has instituted and heightened surveillance and protection arrangements around the Independence Arc, the Independence Square and other national installations to ensure they are not used by any individual or group whose activities may contravene the laws of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, with strengthened security collaboration, robust permit controls, and firm enforcement mechanisms, the Ministry will continue to protect all national monuments under its control from any form of desecration or unauthorised use.

4:16 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Ms Kyei: No supplementary question, thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Habib Iddrisu?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I would like to ask the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts, whether she was aware that two men were kissing at the Independence Square?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, the question is overruled.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, if we look at the question itself, the question says that to prevent the desecration of Independence Act, the Kwame Nkrumah —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The question makes reference to an incident and the Minister, in her answer, said, following that incident, these measures have been put in place. So, for you to be asking the Minister whether she is aware of the very incident being complained

upon, I do not know how I am going to describe your question. So, the question is completely overruled.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I take your guidance, but safe to say that, the question concluded by the—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The question is overruled.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, can I rephrase my question in another way?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please do.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I would like to ask whether the Minister is aware that same-sex activities reportedly occurred at other monuments under her Ministry and what measures she intends to put in place to prevent such incidence?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please file a fresh question, and the Minister will come here and provide the answer.

Yes, Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, I would like to ask whether the Minister is aware of the incident involving a couple alleged to have desecrated the Independence Square and to have been found kissing at the Kwame Nkrumah Mausoleum.

Is she aware they are reported to be from South Africa and claimed, when questioned, that they had been granted

clearance? What assurances can she give this House on the matter?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib, you could file a fresh question to ask the Minister, the country that the people involved in the allegation are coming from, and the Minister will come and provide the answer for you.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I actually spoke as a matter of fact.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Question overruled. Hon Members, let us move to — Yes, Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor?

Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor: Mr Speaker, the broader issue, and that flows from the question and the answer given by the Hon Minister about LGBTQ+ within the tourism industry. What are the concrete steps the Hon Minister is taking to deal with issues of LGBTQ+ within the tourism industry?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, the answer is clear by the Minister. I will therefore not call on the Minister to repeat the answer, so I will not allow the question. I think the Members did not listen to the Minister or read the answer as captured by the *Order Paper*.

Hon Members, let us move to the Question numbered 544, standing in the name of Lawrence Agyinsam, Hemang Lower Denkyira constituency.

Nana Osei-Adjei: Mr Speaker, I come under Order 88(3), with permission and authorisation from the Member of Parliament to do so on his behalf.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please do so.

Employment of Indigenes in Kakum National Park Enclave

Nana Osei-Adjei *on behalf of Mr Lawrence Agyinsam (NPP— Hemang Lower Denkyira)*: Mr Speaker, we beg to ask the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts the plans of the Ministry to expand employment to the indigenes in Kakum National Park enclave who have been marginalised from employment opportunities in the Constituency.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Ms Gomashie: Mr Speaker, the establishment of the Kakum National Park has created direct and indirect job opportunities for the youth in the area. This is because +apart from some of the youth being employed at the park, its presence has led to the springing up of hotels, guest houses, eateries and restaurants, and other social service facilities that provide livelihoods for a number of youths. As a Sector, we are also putting plans in place to implement a Community-Based Ecotourism and Skills Development Programme to train the youth at tourists Centres as Tour Guides, Eco-Guides and other Service Providers. Nevertheless, it must be mentioned that the Kakum National Park is under the management of the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, any supplementary questions? Hon Patrick Yaw Boamah?

Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah: Mr Speaker, I would like to find out from the Hon Minister the cost implications of this Community-Based Ecotourism and Skills Development Programme.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please file a fresh Question.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I would like to find out from the Minister because if you look at the end of her Answer on page 53, she said it must be mentioned that the Kakum National Park is under the management of the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources. I would want to find out whether the answer she provided to this question was provided by the Ministry of Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts or the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources?

Ms Gomashie: From the Ministry of Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we now move to the Question numbered 577, standing in the name of Charles Forson, Member of Parliament for Tema Central.

Mr Dapaah Elvis Osei Mensah: Mr Speaker, I rise under Order 88(3), and I have the permission —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, please, the Order 88(3) that you have mentioned does not give you

automatic leave or authority to ask that Question. So, please.

Mr Osei Mensah: Mr Speaker, Order 88(3), and I have the authority.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, you are now speaking.

Plans to Implement the Blackstar Experience in 2025

Mr Dapaah Elvis Osei Mensah *on behalf of Mr Charles Forson (NPP — Tema Central)*: Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts how the Ministry plans to implement the Black Star experience in 2025 and what institutional partnerships and private sector collaborations are being established to ensure its success as a diaspora tourism brand.

Ms Gomashie: Mr Speaker, the aim of the Black Star Experience is to harness the country's rich cultural heritage, natural beauty and our dynamic creative sector. Our flagship initiative, the Black Star Experience, aims to establish Ghana as the gateway to Africa for the global diaspora, featuring thoughtfully curated cultural, historic, and creative arts experiences in collaboration with the private sector, diplomatic missions, ministries, departments and agencies.

Mr Speaker, the Black Star Experience is not an event. It is a national initiative to rebrand Ghana as Africa's premier destination for Pan-Africanism and cultural emersion. In 2026, the Ministry through its Agencies is working closely with the Black Star

Experience Secretariat, key private sector stakeholders in the hospitality, culture and creative arts space to promote Ghana. The initiative focuses on curated heritage tours, festivals, investment forums, and creative arts as platforms that strengthens diaspora connections.

The Ministry is also engaging strategic partners such as the Diaspora Affairs Office, and international diaspora organisations to promote Ghana as the preferred destination for heritage, culture, and investment. The Ministry has also engaged with creatives in the international space to organise major international musical shows and fashion shows among others.

Mr Speaker, the month of March is our Heritage Month. The 14th of March is Ghana Culture Day. This month lends itself for the celebration of the Black Star Experience.

4:26 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary question?

Mr Osei Mensah: I would like to know how much the Ministry spent on the 2025 Black Star Experience.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please file a fresh Question.

Yes, Hon Shirley Kyei?

Ms Shirley Kyei: Mr Speaker, I would like to ask the Minister, what is the difference between the Black Star Experience and the Year of Return?

Ms Gomashie: Mr Speaker, my understanding of the Year of Return is, it was an invitation to Africans in the Diaspora to come back home and make Ghana their home. We all know that African-Americans consider Ghana as the motherland, so that exercise was really a homecoming for all those who identify with our country. But the Black Star Experience, as I have indicated, is really about everything that we do as Africans, whether the person is on the continent or in the Diaspora. It is not an event; it is a lifestyle change.

Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah: Mr Speaker, I would like to find out from the Minister, in the spirit of forming a lean Government, whether we have a Black Star Experience Secretariat and also a Diaspora Affairs Office.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, the fact that you premised your question with “in the spirit of forming a lean Government”, it has nothing to do with the Question before us. So, you are completely overruled. I will give the floor to Hon Asafo-Adjei.

Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh: Thank you, Mr Speaker. If we look at the premise of the Question, it is to ask “the plans to implement the Black Star Experience in 2025”. It is clear that we are in 2026. I want to find out from the Hon Minister if there have been some lessons that have been learned from the 2025 experience, which would be implemented in the 2026 experience.

Ms Gomashie: Is the question asking if there are any lessons

learned from 2025 that will feed into 2026? Was that the question?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Exactly.

Ms Gomashie: As I said before, because it is not an event and it is a culmination of all the things that identify us as Africans, I suppose that the experience we have all just had of iShowSpeed coming to Ghana, the euphoria that it came with, President Mahama wearing his *fugu* which was addressed as ‘blouse’ and Fugu Wednesday being initiated, I think that there are a lot of lessons to be learned from what happened in 2025, which is the reason we are positioning ourselves to take advantage of every wing that is spread so that we can fly with the celebration of the Black Star Experience.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Question numbered 595 standing in the name of Mr Felix Akwetey Okle, Member of Parliament for Bortianor Ngleshie Amanfro.

Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah — *rose*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, how many supplementary questions do we have to take on one Question? We have other Businesses and there are some of the Questions that are yet to be answered. So, we need to manage Question time, which is ordinarily one hour, but we have exceeded an hour already. We have to be guided by the rules.

Development of Solo Monkey Forest in Bortianor

Mr Felix Akwetey Okle (NDC — Bortianor Ngleshie Amanfro): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts the plans of the Ministry to develop the Solo Monkey Forest in Bortianor to expand the tourism industry for economic development and sustainable ecological management.

Ms Gomashie: Mr Speaker, the Ministry recognises the Solo Monkey Forest as a potential eco-tourism site with both conservation and community livelihood benefits. The Solo Monkey Forest, located at Bortianor, is home to a colony of white nose monkeys, different species of Parrots and other migratory birds, fishes in a naturally protected pond and a host of flora species of medicinal value. It is, therefore, important that we develop the site to complement the needs of beach lovers who regularly visit the area for recreation. This, hopefully, would enhance the economic potential of Bortianor and its environs.

Mr Speaker, I dispatched a team of experts from the Ministry to undertake a reconnaissance visit to the site. The feedback from the visit indicates that the groove is under threat of encroachment by developers. As we speak, the 100-acre reserve has been reduced to about 50 acres and is still reducing. The Ministry through Ghana Tourism Authority in collaboration with the Wildlife Division of the Forestry Commission, the local assembly, the traditional Authority, will assess the site for inclusion in the

Community-Based Ecotourism Development Programme. This initiative aims to improve visitor infrastructure, conservation education, and local enterprise participation. The Ministry will explore partnerships with the Local Assembly, The Ga South Municipal Assembly, the Traditional Authorities of Bortianor and the MP of the Bortianor Ngleshie Amanfro constituency, Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources, conservation NGOs to ensure sustainable ecological management and enhanced tourism value of the area.

Mr Speaker, let me use this opportunity to applaud the Member of Parliament for his passion in leading the charge to have the Solo Monkey Forest recognised as a tourist centre.

Mr Okle: Mr Speaker, I have no supplementary question, except to thank the Hon Minister for her excellent response.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is a constituency-specific Question. On your behalf, I thank the Minister for attending upon the House and responding to all the Questions scheduled for her. Hon Minister, thank you very much.

We have our last Question, that is Question number 649 for the Minister for Sports and Recreation who is seated. I now humbly ask him to take his designated seat, whilst I ask the Hon Member to pose the Question for the Minister's response. I call on Hon Kofi Arko Nokoe to ask the Question numbered 649.

Mr Kofi Arko Nokoe: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I actually meant to stand down the Question because I realised that it was addressed to the wrong Ministry. So, I rise to stand down the Question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: How do you want to stand it down. Do you want to withdraw the Question?

Mr Nokoe: I mean withdraw the Question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Leave is hereby granted. Question is accordingly withdrawn. Hon Minister, you are hereby discharged. Thank you for attending upon the House.

4:36 p.m.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, Hon Kofi Adams cannot go like that. Mr Speaker, at least, he must say something. Mr Speaker, when is he briefing this House about the World Cup, the preparation of the Black Stars—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you are completely out of order.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we can take two important Statements. One is about our late Colleague, and the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts will also make a Statement on Chocolate Day.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Question time has ended. We would now move to the item numbered 7, Statements. Hon Leader, what

Statement do we take? According to the Clerks-at-the-Table, we still do not have a copy of the Statement in honour of our late Member of Parliament for Tamale Central.

Mr Shaib: My humble request would be that, since mine was slated for yesterday and we are ready, we can start while they work on it— *[Interruption]*. No, it is not being captured on the console. So, we can start. Mr Speaker, I am in your hands.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, with all due respect, by the guidelines, when Statements are admitted, the Statements are supposed to be processed by the Clerk. After processing, it will end up being captured on the *Order Paper* for the day. You would realise that because the two respective Statements being referred to, though admitted, were not processed to be taken. That is why it never appeared on the *Order Paper* for today.

However, we are masters of our own rules. If the House desires, we would take the tribute and a Statement on World Radio Day. Hon Members, I have no objection; we can do that. I need to be guided as to the number of contributors that we should take, in view of the fact that we have a long day and today is a Friday.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the sense of the House is that we take these three Statements. The first will be the one in memory of our Colleague, Hon Murtala, the second will be in respect of the Chocolate Day, and the third will be

the World Radio Day. Regarding the comments, we would take two comments from each Side with one from Leadership in respect of each Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Once the House has agreed, I will then give the floor to Hon Prof Seidu Mahama Alidu to make a Statement in the form of a tribute to the late Hon Dr Muhammed Murtala Ibrahim. Hon Member, you have the floor.

STATEMENTS

Tribute to the Late Hon Dr Muhammed Murtala Ibrahim

Prof Seidu Mahama Alidu (NDC — Tamale Central): Mr Speaker, thank you so much for the opportunity. Mr Speaker, it is with a deep sense of sorrow that I wish to pay tribute to the late Hon Dr Muhammed Murtala Ibrahim, the former Member of Parliament for Tamale Central.

Mr Speaker, there are men whose lives remind us that the true measure of existence is not found in years, but in usefulness. Hon Dr Muhammed Murtala Ibrahim was one of those rare souls who understood that time is not to be counted, but to be consecrated. He lived not only by the ticking of the clock, but by the beating of the human heart. His legacy teaches us that life's greatest success is not how long we live, but how deeply we touch others. That the immortality of a good man lies not in monuments, but in memories. Not in wealth, but in worth.

Mr Speaker, he was born on 14th December, 1974 in Tamale, a child of modest beginnings, destined for an extraordinary purpose. From the dusty corridors of St. Peter's Primary and Ghana Senior High Secondary School to the noble lecture halls of the University of Ghana, his journey was one of brilliance, built on discipline and grace. Yet, beyond the pursuit of knowledge stood his anchored faith.

He was a staunch Muslim, deeply rooted in the deen, whose every decision was guided by the Qu'ran and shaped by humility before Allah. His life was a living reminder that intellect without faith is arrogance, and service without spirituality is emptiness. He prayed not only with his lips, but with his deeds. He led not only with vision, but with values. To know him was to see how faith and intellect, when intertwined, can produce a man who serves both God and humanity with equal devotion.

Mr Speaker, from his youthful days as General Secretary of the All African Students' Union, Hon Dr Muhammed Murtala Ibrahim defined leadership not as domination, but as a discipline of service. He believed that power finds its true purpose only when it uplifts others, and he lived that belief with uncommon conviction. Mr Speaker, when the people of Nanton and later Tamale Central entrusted him with their mandate, he carried it not as a title, but as a sacred trust. He built schools, funded scholarships, introduced free Basic Education Certificate Examination (B. E. C. E.) classes, and launched a mobile library that brought knowledge to the

forgotten. He provided clean water through over 50 mechanised boreholes, built clinics in Changli, Sakasaka, and Gumbihini, improved roads, and gave the youth of Kulikuli School an AstroTurf to dream upon. His work was not just development, it was devotion.

Mr Speaker, in Parliament, he was both a scholar and a soldier, brilliant in argument, fearless in principle, and deeply moral in persuasion. As Deputy Minister for Information, and later for Trade and Industry, he brought clarity, vision, and integrity to the governance process. And as Minister for Environment, Science and Technology, he stood at the frontiers of Ghana's modern transformation, championing sustainability, digital advancement, and the balance between progress and planet.

Mr Speaker, then came that sacred and shattering moment when heaven, in its wisdom, proclaimed the light it had loaned to earth. The news did not come as thunder; it came as silence, a silence that screamed. The air grew heavy, time stood still, and a great stillness fell upon Ghana. Dagbon mourned, and Tamale bowed his head in grief. For in that moment, we did not just lose a man, we lost a conscience, a guide, a flame that had lit the path for so many in darkness.

Mr Speaker, as I stand here today, honoured to serve where he once stood, I am reminded that to succeed him is not to replace him, it is to continue his mission. He did not pass down a seat; he passed down a standard. His example challenges us to serve with integrity, to lead with empathy, and to govern with

the heart. Hon Dr Muhammed Murtala Ibrahim was not just a public servant; he was a moral statement.

May Allah (SAWT), the most merciful, grant him mercy and Jannatul Firdaus. And may generations yet unborn speak your name, not with sorrow, but with gratitude.

Thank you so much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, that is the tribute in the form of a Statement in honour of our Colleague, Hon Dr Muhammed Murtala Ibrahim. The floor is now open for contributions on the tribute.

Yes, Hon Kofi Adams?

4:46 p.m.

Minister for Sports and Recreation (Mr Kofi Iddie Adams) (MP): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make a few comments on the tribute ably read by Prof Alidu. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make a few comments on the tribute ably read by Prof Seidu Alidu, Member of Parliament for Tamale Central, in memory of late former Colleague, Dr Murtala Muhammed Ibrahim.

As a young politician myself, we spotted Dr Murtala Muhammed Ibrahim as a young student leader. He caught our attention and we realised he had so much to offer this country. We approached him, and in his days in the university he

did so much to create the necessary awareness. Then fate had it and we all met in Parliament, and we were on the same Committee, Public Accounts Committee. Dr Muhammed Murtala Ibrahim would bring every energy that was needed to the Committee when even we were tired. This is a Committee that reviewed a lot of documents, and in that work, Dr Murtala presented himself in playing that critical oversight role that even information that may not be directly available in reports before us, he had a way of getting such information and bringing it to help the work of the Committee. In our travels to the regions, one would find us together at one point after a tiring day, sharing jokes and talking about the future, the future at that point, we all did not know that I would be standing here today talking about him being no more.

Mr Speaker, he played his role in terms of representing his people, and in one area that our people have come to understand that it is become part and parcel of our responsibility even though not clearly captured in the Constitution about development, Dr Murtala understood that, as MP he needed to play that role. He will go everywhere, low and high, looking for development opportunities for his people, and that explains why within a very short time, we could see a number of development projects, and that, the weekend when the unfortunate incident happened, he was supposed to be inaugurating the commencement of a health project. It tells us how dedicated he was to his duty.

When it comes to law making which is another key role of Parliament, when he was on his feet contributing to the process, one would think that he was actually a lawyer. He truly understood the processes and one clear thing about Dr Murtala, he spoke as if he was so angry and that he had something against someone. But immediately he was done making that statement, the next moment he had forgotten about it. That was who he was, that he did not carry anger beyond the time that most persons would do.

We have truly lost a comrade who called everybody a comrade, even our Hon Colleagues on the other Side who refused to be described as such, he will force it on them that they are comrades beyond the separation, beyond being in another Party we see ourselves as comrades. We have lost him but, Mr Speaker, it tells us one thing that, that is the only day none of us here know when it will come and it is therefore very necessary to prepare for that day and ask ourselves that when we are called what will be said of us.

I pray that the Almighty Allah will forgive him any inequities, anything he may have done untoward, and make his resting place a calm one for him.

Thank you Mr Speaker for the opportunity, and also, the Member who took over after him for making this Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor?

Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor (NPP — Damongo): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I rise to contribute to the brilliant Statement made by my Friend, the Member of Parliament for Tamale Central, in memory of my Friend and Brother, the Hon Dr Ibrahim Murtala Muhammed. Mr Speaker let me put on record that Dr Murtala Ibrahim was not only a Friend, but he was also a brother because as you may know, part of his lineage comes from Daboya in the Savannah Region of Ghana and he spoke impeccable Gonja, and it was of great joy whenever we met and took ourselves into the traditions of Gonja land and Savannah Region.

Mr Speaker we all know that Dr Murtala Muhammed was an intellect and academic *par excellence*. He loved the book and indeed until his untimely death he had piled a good deal of certificates, qualifications and scholarship in academia. He also served his constituents well and diligently and he held his corner very strongly. He was such a strong defender of the National Democratic Congress but with all that, he still made very good friends across the Divide. Although he and I had had our banters and political engagements over the years, that never disturbed our friendship and brotherhood. That goes to testify to Dr Murtala's nature and respect for humanity and the need for us to engage in politics without animosity.

Mr Speaker, I had the privilege and opportunity to engage him even within that short period that he served as Minister for Environment, Science and

Technology. As you know, the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources and the Ministry of Environment Science and Technology work closely. Even before he was sworn in, we had several engagements particularly, as it related to climate change and Ghana's leadership in the climate stage. He had such brilliant ideas and a lot of promise and plans for the Ministry of Environment, Science and Technology, some of which he actually began implementing as Minister.

Mr Speaker, let me conclude by thanking his successor, the Member of Parliament for Tamale Central, Prof Seidu Mahama Alidu, for making this timely and impressive Statement in honour of Dr Ibrahim Murtala Muhammed, and also say that his gentle soul continue to rest in perfect peace.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Fred Agbenyo, you have the floor.

Mr Fred Agbenyo (NDC — Guan): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement made by the Member for Tamale Central.

Mr Speaker, I met the late Hon Dr Ibrahim Murtala Muhammed at the University of Ghana, Legon, where we were all students. When I met Hon Dr Murtala the first time, his sense of humour, the humanity in him. He is one person you always want to be with; his understanding of issues especially, when it comes to the history of this country. He

would debate anybody, especially when it comes to the issue of Dr Kwame Nkrumah and his achievements, and the work that he did throughout this country. Dr Murtala was seen debating anybody who tend to oppose Osagyefo Dr Kwame Nkrumah.

4:56 p.m.

Mr Speaker, when we left University of Ghana and the NDC won elections in 2008, Hon Dr Murtala was appointed to Youth Employment Authority. He served diligently, to the best of his ability.

Issues about youth empowerment were very dear to his heart. Whenever we met him, he would have conversations on how we could empower young people across the country. He was later moved to the Ministry of Information. And then, Mr Speaker, he left one constituency for Tamale Central after losing the election and still won. And anybody who has visited Tamale Central ever since will attest to the fact that this was a man who was committed to his work. The development that he brought to the area is there for all to see.

Mr Speaker, the day before Dr Murtala's passing, we met in this same Chamber, and I agreed to meet the following day for a conversation, not knowing that that was the last time I was interacting with him. When the news came, it was so heartbreaking. Nobody would expect that thing to happen. But as the good book said, in all things, we should give thanks to God. He served his country well. He served our party well.

He served his constituency well. We can only pray that Allah Himself forgive him of all his sins and give him rest wherever he is. We will continue to miss him. We will continue to hold fast to his ideas, philosophy, and beliefs.

Dr Murtala was close to corruption. He will fight it to the very end, and I believe that if all of us politicians can dedicate ourselves to that, this country will go far.

Once again, Mr Speaker, let me thank you very much for the opportunity, and also thank the maker of the Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Mumuni?

Alhaji Nurideen Muhammed Mumuni (NPP — Nalerigu/Salaga): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for this opportunity to comment on the Statement made by the MP for Tamale Central.

Mr Speaker, Hon Murtala was a source of inspiration and motivation to a lot of young people in this country, especially in Tamale Central and the entire northern part of the country. He was a true Muslim, deeply rooted in the *deen* of Islam, and he had a commanding understanding of Islamic teachings. I think what Hon Murtala needs now is our prayers. May the Almighty Allah have mercy on his soul, wherever he is.

Mr Speaker, today being Friday, I want to use this opportunity to call on my Colleague Muslims in this Chamber to recite *Qul huwal laahu ahad* for Hon

Murtala and all our departed souls. *Bismillaahir Rahmaanir Raheem, Allah Hus-samad, Lam yalid wa lam yoolad, Wa lam yakul-lahoo kufuwan ahad.* This is what I think Hon Murtala needs right now.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: How do you expect the *Hansard* to capture this?

Alhaji Mumuni: Mr Speaker, to wit, may the soul of Hon Murtala rest in peace. Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I do not think all that you have said only means “May his soul rest in peace.”

Yes, Minority Leadership?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu (NPP — Tolon): Mr Speaker, we in this Parliament have lost a Brother, an Hon Colleague, and a Minister. I was very close to Hon Murtala. He was a father and a teacher, and everyone knew him in the Northern Region.

Mr Speaker, just going through the Statement, and when his successor, Prof Alidu, addressed him as Dr Muhammed Murtala Ibrahim, I realised what he told me some time ago. He always told me not to address him as Dr Muhammed Murtala, but rather as Alhaji Murtala. Because when he dies, his PhD will be gone. But he will die with the title “Alhaji”.

Sometime in 2024, he came to my office, and he told me, “Hon Habib, I have sent over 100 people to Hajj, but do you know that I have never been to Hajj

myself? When I was a Deputy Minister and a CEO, I always assisted my constituents and people in need by supporting their pilgrimage to Hajj. I do not know when I will die. I want to perform the Hajj with my wife.”

I was then a member of the Ghana Hajj Board. I told him it was a good idea. Then he said, “I want to do it with my wife.” So, my wife and I, and he and his wife, all performed the Hajj together. In fact, we were in one room.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Which of your wives?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, Hon Murtala performed the Hajj with his beautiful wife, and I performed the Hajj with my beautiful wife, Hajia Asma Osalifu.

Mr Speaker, when we performed the Hajj, I remember that at one point I told him we should take a bus, as we were supposed to walk about 13 kilometres on foot with his wife. He then told me this is a religious exercise. The Holy Prophet did it. We can do it. He, I, and others walked more than 23 kilometres on foot from Muzdalifah to Jamarat and then to the Haram. We walked back from Haram to Mina on that day.

Mr Speaker, a year later, he returned to my office during Ramadan and said, “I want to perform the last 10 days of Ramadan in Makkah, doing Umrah.” And I asked him, but we just returned from Hajj last year. He told me that if one performs Umrah during the last 10 days of Ramadan, it is as if one has performed

Hajj alongside the Holy Prophet. So we should go. The Rt Hon Speaker, Alban Bagbin, made an initiative to the Muslim Caucus to help us perform Umrah. He and I performed Umrah during Ramadan last year. He was supposed to go to Paris for a conference and join me in Mecca. He asked me to book a room for him because he was not sure whether he would live to see another year. And this is something he wanted to do. I went to Umrah again with my wife. He later joined us.

Mr Speaker, that is the end of the story. A story that ended in a very painful death, which I am happy with. I am a Muslim, and knowing Alhaji Murtala and how he died, I am very happy he died that way because it is stated in our religion, and it is our belief that if one dies in a painful situational death, any punishment that God is supposed to give them, that is the punishment, and they go straight to Jannah. That means that they will be in Paradise. I am very convinced that today Alhaji Murtala is in Paradise as we try to either eulogise him or speak about this painful and tragic death that we see in this country.

I was happy that when my Colleague, Hon Mumuni, was reciting verses of the Quran, the verse he recited was in response to the oneness of Allah when the Holy Prophet was confronted and asked about who his God was. So when he said *Qul huwal laahu ahad*, it was a command, "Say: He is Allah, the One and Only". And he went on to say my Lord is self-sufficient, *Lam yalid wa lam yoolad*, He begetteth not, nor is He begotten. And there was nothing

compared to God. That is how I would describe Hon Murtala. I think that as Colleagues, we should love each other because life is very short.

Yesterday, I was in a meeting with the Majority Leader at the Business Committee when we heard that two of our Colleagues were involved in an accident: The Minister for Education and the Deputy Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations. Death can come at any time, in a second, in a minute.

5:06 p.m.

Last night, my Colleague, Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib, and I were at 37 Military Hospital to visit the Minister for Education and the Hon Deputy Minister. Anything can happen to us. In this Chamber, we do politics, but let us have a clean heart. Whatever we say in this Chamber should not follow us out, because we would never know when one would die, and we should not harbour things.

Mr Speaker, sometimes I say certain things in this Chamber, and anybody who knows me very well, knows I do not take the matter of another to bed. No, I do not have that space in my heart. Whatever I say here, I make sure that I leave it here, because I might not even sleep and wake up.

So, as we eulogise him, I will call on Colleagues that when we are here, the 276 of us, we are family; we are one. That day, we never knew that we were going to lose one of our Colleagues. I

will urge us that we should love each other. It is in the Bible and in the *Qu'ran*.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Chief Whip?

Majority Chief Whip (Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor): Mr Speaker, I am seizing the opportunity to add my voice to the Statement commemorating the departure of Our brave Brother, and we are eulogising him, I should say.

Mr Speaker, everyone in this Chamber knows of the relationship that he and I had. For that weekend, we had agreed that we would travel to Tamale for him to continue with his community engagements. Usually, any time we go to Tamale, he had an accommodation ready for me. We would normally do the rounds early in the morning and in the evening, and then in the afternoons, we do other rounds.

Mr Speaker, Hon Murtala was a formidable voice on this Floor and outside of it. He had strong convictions about his views and positions on matters. Normally for, but on occasions that he is against a person, then trouble for the person. He was such a passionate Member of Parliament. He had had such an impact in Tamale Central and I should say, within the Tamale Metropolis. Because of him, I am quite popular in Tamale, because within the past eight years, we have been very close, especially because we bonded well

on the Public Accounts Committee, where we worked closely. He became a friend, a brother, and a confidant. Often, we would get together and talk about our futures. It is painful we had to lose him. So much so that he just evaporated. He was not sick. Murtala just vanished. There are several persons on this Floor who, for the sheer relationship they had, they are not even able to speak.

We pray that the Lord forgives his transgressions and receives him in heaven. I am concerned about his son, a very lovely boy. I believe that he will grow to take after his father, in character, public appeal and also become a very formidable national figure, whether in politics or in academia. I remember that when we lost Hon Kumi, and a Statement was brought for us to eulogise him, Murtala had come in, he called me and said that I should wait because he wanted to add his voice. So, he was here. If I recall, I think the Hon Second Deputy Speaker was in the Chair, and we had agreed on numbers. He came to me and said, "if you do not, we will beat you outside". I mean, that was the kind of person he was. Then he had the opportunity, and he spoke eloquently and fondly about who Hon Kumi was. Even though Hon Kumi had not spent too much time on this Floor, but he spoke passionately about his work. He quoted the Quran copiously that day. That all of us could sleep and not wake up.

And so, again, he spoke to us about loving one another. As Hon Habib Iddrisu said, we may do things on the Floor, but at all material times, we must let love be the determinant so that we do

not hurt each other too much because persons have been here, and they have left. We, too, will leave someday. But the memories and the fellow feeling that we shared are what others will remember.

So, Mr Speaker, we should love one another. Hon Murtala was a Member of Parliament. I remember our days on the other Side —*[Interruption]*— the Hon Member of Kpandai knows I love him. He knows the things we did were on principle. So, that is by the way. I remember our days on the other Side when Hon Muntaka put us into some formidable group of seven. Occasionally, we will be nine. But I, Hon Murtala, Hon Yusif, Hon Sam George, Hon Suhuyini, Hon Edward Bawa, Hon Ernest Norgbey, Hon Jinapor, and the arrowhead was Hon Isaac Adongo. We did things that politics permitted us to do. We became formidable on the Floor, and occasionally, when we had to do those things, during Consideration, Mr Speaker, you joined us and led the process. So, he left such an indelible mark on this Floor. So, we can only emulate the work, the passion, and the commitment that he demonstrated to the parliamentary work. I cannot say much. I can only wish his young family the best and — I am in Leadership so I would not say “urge Leadership” but rather, maybe with the support of Leader, we may have to think of putting some structure together so that occasionally, the Hon Leader mooted the idea, I believe we

have to go back to it and occasionally, reach out to his family.

Mr Speaker, it is very necessary because of the nature of his departure. If I may clarify, preparations were not done. So, it will become our duty to reach out to the family every now and then to let the widow and the children know that we are here to support them anytime they need us.

Mr Speaker, with these words, I want to thank Professor Alidu for doing this. It delayed, but today, we are doing it.

So, I thank you for the opportunity and to urge the entire Tamale Central and the National Democratic Congress (NDC) executives, they know me very well. They should support Professor Alidu to continue the work that Honourable Alhaji Murtala Muhammed was doing for them.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

5:16 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, thank you very much. May we observe a minute silence. Let us be on our feet.

[A minute of silence was observed]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: May the soul of Alhaji Dr Muhammed Murtala Ibrahim rest in the bosom of the Almighty Allah. Amen.

We will take three minutes of suspension, then we will continue with the Statement in the name of Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib.

5:17 p.m. — *Sitting suspended.*

5:20 p.m. — *Sitting resumed.*

[MR FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER, MR BERNARD AHIAFOR, IN THE CHAIR]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, kindly resume your seats.

Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib, you have the honour of making the Statement on World Radio Day on the floor.

World Radio Day

Second Deputy Minority Whip (Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for indulging me. Mr Speaker, yesterday, 12th February, 2026, marked another significant commemoration of World Radio Day. A global observance proclaimed by the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) and formally adopted through the UN's General Assembly Resolution.

Mr Speaker, this day celebrates radio as a powerful medium that shapes public discourse, preserves cultural heritage, facilitates democratic participation, and serves as a critical instrument for information dissemination across geographical, socio-economic, and technological divides. World Radio Day

recognises radio's unique capacity to reach diverse audiences, foster community dialogues, and provide platforms for marginalised voices that may otherwise remain unheard in our national conversations.

Mr Speaker, the history of radio broadcasting in Ghana is inseparably linked to our colonial past and represents a fascinating evolution from an instrument of colonial administration to a vibrant pillar of democratic governance and cultural expression. The early years of radio in Ghana were characterised by centralised state control, with broadcasting serving primarily governmental information dissemination and nation-building objectives during the Nkrumah era. The landscape of radio broadcasting in Ghana has undergone a dramatic transformation since the liberalisation of the airwaves in the 1990s, when the National Media Commission began licensing private radio stations following the promulgation of the 1992 Constitution, which guaranteed freedom of expression and media pluralism.

According to the National Communications Authority's 2024 annual report, Ghana now boasts over 450 licensed radio stations across the country, comprising state-owned broadcasters, commercial stations, community radio stations, and campus-based broadcasters, representing an extraordinary proliferation that has fundamentally democratised access to information and transformed Ghana's media landscape.

Mr Speaker, the role that radio has played in strengthening Ghana's democracy cannot be overstated, and this House must acknowledge the medium's vital contribution to our political development and democratic consolidation. Radio serves multiple critical functions within our democratic architecture, beginning with its fundamental role in information dissemination, ensuring that citizens across all 16 regions, regardless of literacy levels or economic status, have access to news about Government policies, parliamentary proceedings, electoral processes, and civic responsibilities. The United Nations Development Programmes 2023 Assessment of Media and Democracy in West Africa highlighted Ghana as a regional leader in press freedom, noting that radio's penetration into rural areas and peri-urban communities has significantly enhanced political participation and governmental accountability.

Mr Speaker, radio stations across Ghana have consistently provided platforms for marginalised and vulnerable populations, including women, youth, persons with disabilities, and ethnic minorities, to articulate their concerns, challenge injustice, and participate in national conversations from which they might otherwise be excluded. Mr Speaker, the watchdog function performed by radio journalists cannot be underestimated, as investigative reporting broadcasts across radio stations has exposed corruption, inefficiency and malfeasance in both public and private sectors, compelling

institutional reforms and protecting public interest.

Mr Speaker, during election cycles, radio serves as the primary medium through which political parties communicate their manifestos. Candidates engage with constituents, and the Electoral Commission (E. C.) disseminates vital information about registration, voting procedures, and results, making radio indispensable to the electoral process.

Mr Speaker, as World Radio Day was commemorated yesterday, the Government of Ghana is respectfully asked to issue an urgent call for the creation of an enabling environment within which media institutions can function effectively without fear, intimidation, or arbitrary interference. The Government must demonstrate its commitment to press freedom by ensuring that radio stations and journalists are protected from attacks, harassment, and violence perpetrated by security agencies and political operatives or any other actors seeking to silence critical voices.

To my fellow Hon Members of Parliament, we must commit to enacting robust laws that institutionalise protections for radio broadcasting and ensure that sectors' sustainable growth and development. In commemoration of this important day, we all, regardless of political affiliation, must champion media freedom in our constituencies, speak out against attacks on journalists, and recognise that a free and vibrant press ultimately serves the interests of

democracy and national development rather than partisan political objectives.

Media owners must ensure that their investment in the professional development and capacity building of radio practitioners, ensuring that journalists and broadcasters possess the requisite skills, ethical grounding, and resources necessary to discharge their responsibilities with fairness, accuracy, and integrity. Mr Speaker, media owners must resist the temptation toward sensationalism and yellow journalism that prioritises ratings and revenue over truth and public interest. Radio stations must establish and enforce rigorous editorial standards, fact-checking mechanisms, and ethical guidelines that prevent the spread of misinformation and disinformation. Media organisations must provide adequate remuneration and working conditions for journalists, recognising that poorly compensated and insecure media workers are vulnerable to corruption and ethical practices that undermine the profession's credibility.

Mr Speaker, as we conclude this commemoration, let us remember that radio is far more than a technological medium or a commercial enterprise. Radio represents the very lifeblood of democratic discourse, the amplifier of citizen voices, the guardian against governmental excess, and the bridge connecting our diverse communities into a united or unified national conversation. From the earliest broadcast during colonial administration to the current explosion of stations across our nation, radio has evolved into a crucial democratic infrastructure that informs,

educates, entertains and empowers our people. The health of our democracy is directly related to the vitality of our media sector. And the freedom of our radio stations to broadcast without fear or favour stands as a fundamental measure of our commitment to constitutional governance and human rights.

Mr Speaker, let me highly commend the likes of Chairman General Kwame Sefa Kayi, OB of *Asempa FM*, Nana Yaw Kesse of *Peace FM*, Bola Ray, Bernard Avle, Kofi Kum Bilson, Kojo Yankson, Samuel Atta Mensah and all radio presenters.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, that is the Statement on World Radio Day. Hon Member, you have the floor.

5:30 p.m.

Mr Nelson Kofi Djabab (NDC — Krachi East): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement made by Hon Member for Weija-Gbawe, Jerry Ahmed Shaib.

Mr Speaker, while I commend the maker of this Statement for his deep research into the topic, that is, radio broadcasting in Ghana, it is important to mention that radio broadcasting has led to education, especially, in our rural communities, as it has informed some communities in the rural areas. Rural

radio broadcasting also entertains, empowers our people, as it encourages some of them to speak out on some of the activities that are nefarious, which could have been hidden and would never have been known.

Mr Speaker, it is important to also mention that all these good achievements in radio broadcasting will forever remain a mirage if the rights of journalists are not protected. For this reason, it is important to mention that the 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana stipulates that every Ghanaian should have the right to speak, the right to express himself at any time, without any interference or intimidation.

Mr Speaker, while I commend the maker of the Statement, I also want to commend the Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations, the Minister of State in charge of Government Communications, the Government, and the National Security, that currently we can see that there is that freedom being expressed everywhere by journalists. Unlike some time past, Mr Speaker, some journalists were forced into self-imposed exile simply because of the media comments that they made. So, I want to use this opportunity to also commend the Government led by His Excellency President Mahama for granting that media freedom, once again restoring that confidence in our journalists.

Thank you very much for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Nana Asafo-Agyei Ayeh?

Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh (NPP — Bosome Freho): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I want to commend the maker of the Statement, Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib. Exactly a year today, on this very Floor, I also made a Statement commemorating the World Radio Day.

Mr Speaker, my Colleague, Hon Shaib, has done a good work, leaving little for us to speak about. The importance of radio in this country can never be underestimated. The contribution that it has given to us, and how it has enriched our democracy, is something that we always need to commend, and we should not forget to celebrate days like this.

Mr Speaker, as for the importance of radio, he has mentioned it, but I only want to look at one aspect that was not really highlighted, which is the challenges of radio in this contemporary world or space now. One of the challenges is the shift in technology. There are cars that are coming now that do not have the AM and the FM buttons. The technology drive in the car does not even create space for some of these radios to function in them.

Mr Speaker, there is another crippling issue that has to do with the generational shift. Young people of these

days, particularly “Gen Zs”, find radio as archaic, outmoded, old-fashioned. It is something that we need to look at. There was an article titled *Radio is Not Dead, It's Alive and Evolving*. It is important that we highlight these things and let the practitioners know that as we are evolving, and technology is changing, as the media space is getting fragmented, it is important that they also evolve to meet the changes of the day.

Mr Speaker, you mentioned another key critical issue that has to do with protecting the rights of the practitioners. It is important. Our laws provide for the protection of the rights of the practitioners. While we are encouraging that these laws are implemented to the latter, it is critical that we check the practitioners and how they conduct themselves.

Mr Speaker, he talked about fact-finding and checking the things they put out, which is critical. He mentioned misinformation. It is important. Now, when you go to our media space, particularly the radio space, there is a lot of misinformation, and you ask yourself, what due diligence, what fact-checks did some of these practitioners do? It is important that while we are talking about their rights, we must also highlight the importance of them being professional in what they do and how they do what they do.

Now, I think we as a House, we should look at how to test the professionalism of those who practice journalism. How do we qualify them? On what basis do we say this one is

qualified and passed to even speak on radio, to present a programme, or to speak about very important national issues? What are the criteria that we use to determine some of these people? We are checking the lawyers, we are checking the doctors, we are checking nurses, and all other professionals. It is important that journalists must also have a certain benchmark to check them so that we do not have people who are not qualified being in our airspace and misinforming Ghanaians about a lot of things.

Mr Speaker, I must also add my voice to the very professional journalists Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib commented on. I think there are more, and not to mention some names and leave some out, I also commend all professional journalists in this country and tell them that we appreciate their work as we celebrate World Radio Day. There cannot be radio without them practicing in that space. So, we commend and appreciate them. We are only urging that they help build and strengthen the democracy we are practicing.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We have taken a comment apiece on the Statement on radio. Do I move to the Leadership?

Mr Shaib — rose —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Shaib, you make the Statement; you cannot contribute to it, so you have nothing to yield.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, but I am in Leadership. I have a dual role. So, Mr Speaker, please recognise me.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will recognise you in that capacity, but not because you are yielding, because you have nothing to yield.

Mr Shaib: I withdraw, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Dr Kabiru Mahama?

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama (NPP — Walewale): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, it will be amiss that such a brilliant and well-researched Statement is made by the respected Member for Weija-Gbawe, without comment from Members of the Committee on Information and Communications.

Mr Speaker, the foundation for that Statement is grounded in the Constitution of the Republic of Ghana. Article 162 has established the freedom of the media, and Article 21 specifically guarantees the freedom of expression for every person, which includes the freedom of the media and press. These constitutional guarantees are for every person, and it is for good reasons the framers of this Constitution made for us those laws.

5:40 p.m.

Mr Speaker, as we celebrate World Radio Day, we need to remind ourselves that it is in furtherance of this

Constitution that the criminal libel laws were removed or repealed from our statutes, and that leaders of old and people who have been in this House before us, saw the need to repeal any law that seeks to inhibit or fetter on the freedom of expression, and the fourth estate of the realm was to be given unfettered access to report without fear or favour.

Mr Speaker, the radio is one of the foremost tools we have used to advance development in this country. I remember that, as a young boy, I listened to most of what was happening in Accra on Savannah Radio, a national broadcaster in the Northern Region. Radio has become a tool for national development. We had what we call farm radio, where rural farmers get to learn about the rudiments and agricultural practices through the radio.

Mr Speaker, we had a radio for health, where we got educated on basic health promotion, including personal hygiene. The radio has become an indispensable tool for national development. As we celebrate this day, we need to ask ourselves whether the national radio still has the role that was prepared and played of old by the current radio we have? I beg to answer this question in the negative. There seems to be a shift of attention away from national discourses or things that will promote national unity and development to issues that promote clicks and likes. It appears that if a radio station is not a merchant of controversy, it has no listenership.

I think that operators of radio stations would have to recalibrate and relook at how they see their radio stations and how they see and use their platform to promote national cohesion and development. Mr Speaker, but as we talk about the importance of national radio or radio to national development, even the very essence of participative democracy and inclusive governance, the radio has a cardinal role to play. I think that we cannot overflog the importance of radio to our national development.

Mr Speaker, the threat of new media is a great threat to the survival of radio and these radio stations, as we even mentioned, are a source of entertainment, education, and information for people who are located in rural areas. For any nation, if one has a radio, one can listen to whatever is happening in any part of the country, especially once a radio network is within the area. But the proliferation of new media is one of the threats to traditional media, and much so for people who are in rural areas.

Mr Speaker, how do we position our national media in line with Article 163 of the Constitution to enable the national radio station play its role? I also want to acknowledge the abuse of radio, as my Colleagues have stated. We know of the Rwanda experience, Mr Speaker, and I commend the National Communication Authority (NCA) in line with ensuring and instilling discipline in sanitising the radio space. They have received calls to revoke the licences of certain radio stations. But we need to caution them

that the abuse of the platform is a recipe for danger or chaos, because we have had it happen in Rwanda, where radio stations were the basis for a genocide. I think that we need to be careful about it.

I also want to note the threat to Article 121 of the Constitution. In this country, the freedom of the media is endangered. The editorial independence of journalists is threatened in this country, and I want to use *GhOne* TV as an example. Lily Mohammed of *GhOne* TV expressed views that criticised a government official. Less than 24 hours later, she was asked to withdraw that statement, the media house apologised and the statement was pulled down. There was nothing defamatory about that statement. There was nothing libellous about that statement. But Lily Mohammed was asked to withdraw. That is a huge threat.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you should be guided that in commenting on a Statement, your comment must not generate debate. Restrict yourself to the rules and conclude.

Dr A. K. T. Mahama: Mr Speaker, I am very clear, and I am not engaging—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please conclude.

Dr A. K. T. Mahama: Mr Speaker, I will conclude. But I want to make the point clear that I am not violating the rules of this House.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up. Resume your seat.

Dr A. K. T. Mahama: Mr Speaker, this is so unfair, and I must put this on record.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: What is unfair? The rule says your comment must not exceed five minutes. It is not everlasting time that you have. If I said you are not operating within the rules, your comment would generate debate.
[Uproar]

Hon Member, I do not know you to be disrespectful. The rule says that when the Speaker is speaking, all other Members must listen to the Speaker in silence. Your conduct is noticed to be disorderly. Clearly, I must place it on record. We are guided by rules, and I have to ensure that we operate within the ambit of the rules. I am fair to all manner of people.

So, to say that I am not fair to you, I take great exception to it. You will notice that you even spoke beyond the prescribed period. I warned you to conclude, and told you that your statement must not generate into a debate. What is unfair about this?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I wish to pray that, please.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, I do not like any Hon Member to take liberty for licence.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, let me take this opportunity to respectfully ask that

you calm down for us as well so we can make some progress.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

I think that, Hon Colleagues, should try as much as possible, and I mean no disrespect to anybody, defer to the Chair. The Speaker gives guidance. Hon Members may not be happy, but how you react may also spoil your case. I think Hon Members should be careful what they are doing. It is not good practice. I am on my feet speaking about the same thing, and the Hon Member is sitting there, talking back at me. It does not function that way. I have been in this Chamber for more than a decade, so please be careful. Do not do that. Do not extend it to the Speaker.

The Hon Member may not like something, but he must not respond that way. If we all start behaving that way, this Chamber will not be governable by anybody. That is why we have a Speaker. It is not always the case that we will all think that the Speaker is treating us fairly, but so be it. We live with it because whatever it is, they will have to exercise control over the conversations that are taking place in the Chamber.

This is a very important Statement, and I think the Hon Kabiru was doing very well in his commentary. In fact, I noted so many things that I wanted to say, but I noticed that he was covering all of them, and we encourage the younger

ones in the Chamber to do well. Sometimes I come and sit here, and the whole day I say nothing. For today, I would have said nothing, but I just felt that World Radio Day is such an important matter that I should also lend my support to the Statement that has been made.

5:50 p.m.

I want to focus on responsible radio practice, which is a theme that has recurred several times in the comments made by some Members of the House. I was going to build on what he said about Rwanda as an example. The genocide in Rwanda, from what the historians have said, was largely promoted using the radio. On radio, some tribes were demonised, and on radio, the killing, the maiming, the humiliation of some ethnic groups was idealised as if it were ideal to do that, or legitimate to go and kill, and that was what really enabled the genocide to occur. So, while radio is a powerful tool for development, as has been emphasised in today's Statements, it can be very destructive if not managed well.

I come from a constituency that has experienced a lot of violence in recent times, and consistently, radio has been the platform that people have used to incite violence. In the North, sometimes we listen to radio, and we could see that people are deliberately inciting violence. Then of course, the issues of freedom of expression comes up. Recently, the radio stations have been participatory in the sense that they allow phone-ins. Sometimes, the host in their

commentary, they are guided because they are professional. The problem is those who are phoning in, who are not professionals, who are not guided in the way that they speak on radio and they are faceless. So, they can be the ones actually spewing out all the violence, promoting the violence, promoting ethnocentrism and promoting religious intolerance and some of the hosts deliberately allow them. They are not journalists, and they have not been trained and yet, they have become regular fixtures on some radio stations. Every evening, they will phone in, and when they phone in, they will say things that should never be said on radio. When the security agencies come after the station, then there is an issue of violation of freedom of expression or press freedom. Yet, we have a society that is characterized by its diversity. We are diverse ethnically, religiously and in terms of our various social and economic status, and these differences can easily be exploited by demagogues to cause divisions, to cause anarchy, and to bring down everything that we have invested in. That is why we need to be heard on World Radio Day, cautioning that while radio is a powerful tool for building society positively, it is also a powerful weapon for destroying and raising the entire society to the ground.

So, I urge Colleagues in our various engagements in our constituencies to try and then talk to those who own the radio stations, the hosts, about their responsibility to help us maintain the integrity of our democracy. We go around the country, and this country is blessed with a lot of literacy. I would say

that a lot of the literacy that has been achieved in this country is largely a function of the radio stations, even more than the classrooms. Our democracy is doing well largely because of the radio stations, because of the way journalists and radio stations continue to educate the general populace. So, let us keep it that way. Let us protect radio freedom. Dr Kabiru has already spoken a lot about the issues of financing, the issues about technology, and the threat to radio as a result of the new media that is emerging. So, I will not belabour the point, but to commend the maker of the Statement for such an important Statement on an auspicious day like this. We missed the opportunity yesterday to make it, but better late than never.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, thank you very much. That brings us to the end of the Statement on the World Radio Day.

We have two Statements on the Chocolate Day. We will let them read the same together. But before doing so, let me place on record that every Speaker is here to guide based on the rules, and once we preside as speakers, we listen to everybody attentively and ensure that we operate within the rules.

The maker of the Statement, in making the Statement, makes no reference to any occurrence within the current government or past government in relation to any radio station or any journalist in any manner

whatsoever. Clearly, there is nothing in the Statement that could generate a debate. Therefore, in commenting on the Statement, once we are talking about a specific occurrence, whether in the past government or within the current government, that clearly is likely to generate debates which offend Order 93 (5) of our own Standing Orders. So, having listened to that, under the current government, something happening on, for instance, *GhOne*, clearly, that is a matter that will generate into a debate because the category of the people that we are talking about would have no opportunity on the floor to defend themselves. So, other Members may get up to say they want to respond. So, we need to be guided jealously by the rules. If you engage in that and you are being admonished, that does not amount to any element of unfairness.

So, I take a great exception to the use of the word that I am being unfair to Dr Kabiru Mahama.

On this note, I will first call on the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts to deliver the first Statement, and thereafter, Hon Doyoe will have the floor to also do so. We will combine the two Statements and contribute to it, and thereafter, we will move to any other Business.

Hon Minister, you have the floor.

National Chocolate Day

Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts (Ms Abba Dzifa Gomashie): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, Happy Chocolate Day. I am grateful for the opportunity to make a Statement on the celebration of National Chocolate Week, which is observed annually culminating in the celebration of the National Chocolate Day, which coincides with Valentine's Day on 14th February.

Mr Speaker, this important national celebration was instituted to promote the consumption of locally produced chocolate and other chocolate-based products, highlight the health benefits of chocolate, and deepen awareness of cocoa's contribution to Ghana's economy, tourism, and national identity. The theme for this important celebration is "Eat Chocolate, Stay Healthy, and Grow Ghana", with a sub-theme, "Experience Ghana, Share the Cocoa Love".

Mr Speaker, chocolate is a symbol of Ghana's agricultural excellence, industrial potential, tourism, identity, and national resilience. Ghana remains one of the world's leading producers of premium quality cocoa, and the crop continues to sustain millions of livelihoods across the agricultural value chain, from our hard-working farmers and transporters to processors, manufacturers, exporters, to retailers.

6:00 p.m.

Mr Speaker, this also forms an important part of the Black Star Experience, our flagship National Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts programme, which seeks to celebrate everything African and especially

everything Ghanaian. Chocolate tourism from cocoa farms to chocolate factories and tasting experiences represent an exciting frontier for domestic tourism growth, youth engagement and private sector participation and that is what we are pursuing.

Mr Speaker, beyond consumption, cocoa represents significant opportunities for industrialisation, job creation and entrepreneurship, particularly for the youth. While Ghana is globally recognised for producing high-quality cocoa beans, we must continue to expand the value addition through local processing and chocolate manufacturing. Increasing domestic cocoa processing will create jobs in food technology, packaging, branding, logistics, agribusiness and creative marketing, among others. When Ghanaians choose locally made chocolate, *fugu*, shea butter, crafts, *et cetera*, we are supporting Ghanaian farmers, strengthening local manufacturing, promoting tourism experiences, creating jobs for young people and retaining value within our national economy.

Indeed, every piece of Ghana made chocolate consumed is an investment in Ghana's future. Our challenge as a country now is to ensure we make chocolate affordable and accessible. Chocolate tourism, including factory visits, cocoa farm tours, chocolate tasting events, culinary demonstrations and cultural showcases, offers a unique opportunity to diversify Ghana's tourism offerings and increase visitor spending. As part of efforts to promote domestic

tourism, hotels, restaurants and tourist sites across the country are encouraged during this period to feature chocolate themed menus and experiences. This collaboration between agriculture, tourism and creative arts demonstrates how inter-sector partnerships can drive inclusive economic growth.

But, Mr Speaker, we cannot look at the cocoa sector in isolation. The cocoa sector is affected by other sectors. The communities that plant the cocoa are the same communities at the mercy of *galamseymen*. We must all rise to the occasion and add our collective voices to the call to end *galamsey*, to protect our farmland and our water bodies from destruction and ultimately destroy our cocoa farms.

In conclusion, Mr Speaker, the celebration of National Chocolate Week and National Chocolate Day calls on all Ghanaians to firstly, support locally made chocolate and cocoa products, and secondly, promote Ghana as a chocolate and cocoa tourism destination. On behalf of the Ministry of Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts, I invite Hon Members of this House and all Ghanaians to celebrate Chocolate Week by sharing of Ghanaian chocolate as a symbol of love, supporting local businesses and sharing the cocoa story of Ghana with the world.

Mr Speaker, I want your permission to make a presentation to you, the Clerk's Office and the Rt Hon Speaker, and of course, every Member in this Chamber is going to receive their own bite of the GoldenTree chocolate. Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

[Hon Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts presented parcels of chocolates to Clerk to Parliament]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you so much, Hon Minister. Hon Members, let me use the opportunity on behalf of the Rt Hon Speaker, the Clerk and Hon Members that will soon be receiving the chocolate to thank the Hon Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts. Hon Minister, Mama Dzamedo I, we thank you sincerely for your kind gesture. I will now proceed to give the floor to Hon Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe to also make her Statement on the same subject matter. You have the floor.

First Deputy Majority Whip (Ms Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make this Statement on the occasion of 14 February, which falls on Saturday, Ghana's National Chocolate Day; a day set aside to celebrate one of our most valuable natural resources, cocoa, and to promote the consumption of chocolate and other cocoa-based products made in Ghana. Mr Speaker, National Chocolate Day is not only symbolic, it is strategic. It underscores our collective resolve to move beyond the export of raw cocoa beans to value addition, agro-processing and industrialisation, which remain critical pillars of national development. In this regard, I wish to commend H.E. President John Dramani Mahama and his Government for the renewed commitment towards industrialisation, particularly policies aimed at strengthening local manufacturing, supporting agro-processing industries, the implementation of the 24-hour

Economic policy, and positioning Ghana to drive maximum economic benefit from its cocoa sector. These efforts align with our long-standing national aspiration to create jobs, enhance foreign exchange earnings, and build a resilient economy.

Mr Speaker, I urge the Government to continue and deepen this effort, especially by supporting cocoa-processing companies, the private sector particularly, and expanding markets for finished cocoa products by adding value to our cocoa beans here at home. We will not only increase national revenue, but also empower Ghanaian workers, particularly women entrepreneurs, across the value chain.

Mr Speaker, while National Chocolate Day coincides with Valentine's Day, it is important that we also take a moment to advise our young people, who form the backbone of our nation's future. I respectfully encourage the youth in particular to celebrate responsibly and to avoid unprotected sex activities during this period of festivity. Our young people must remain mindful of the fact that they are future leaders with great prospects, not only for themselves but also for their families and for Ghana as a whole.

6:10 p.m.

Responsible choices today will safeguard their health, preserve their ambitions and secure their contributions to national development tomorrow.

Mr Speaker, as we enjoy Ghanaian chocolate and celebrate love, in its truest sense, love for the country, responsibility and self-discipline, let us recommit ourselves to building a prosperous, healthy and industrialised Ghana.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the two Statements are ably made. They are before you. It is now time for contributions by Members on the Statements.

Mr Emmanuel Kwaku Boam (NDC — Pru East): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I must commend the makers of the Statements, our Hon Minister and the First Deputy Majority Whip.

Mr Speaker, tomorrow's celebration, which we are eulogising today, happens to be one of a kind that matters so much in the calendar of this country and the world at large. Inasmuch as we want to celebrate the love that exists between friends and that of lovers, it is also important that we also mark this day as Chocolate Day and the Statements come to confirm it.

The theme celebrated this time is to "*Eat Chocolate, Stay Healthy and Grow Ghana*". This is most timely as our farmers of cocoa, which is actually used in the production of chocolate, need to be appreciated and thanked for the good services they do for Mother Ghana. In fact, it is because we deem them so unique that this day has been set aside to

celebrate Chocolate Day. So, I want to use this opportunity to thank the cocoa farmers and tell them the work they do for mother Ghana is equally noticed and that is why today has been set aside to celebrate them. As we have this chocolate, we also want to say “thank you” for the good work they do for us.

Mr Speaker, it is time we looked at how we would make chocolate less expensive, as the first Statement read, indicated. Inasmuch as we want people to patronise chocolate, it is too expensive for ordinary people to patronise, especially when it comes to Pru East, where my constituency is. They see it as having to live some kind of lifestyle to purchase one chocolate. So, to them, chocolate is not a must-have. They would prefer to buy other things than to buy chocolate, but the medicinal and the health benefits that come with chocolate is enormous. I want to seize this opportunity to also add my voice to the Minister, calling for a reduced price when it comes to occasions like this, so that we can share in the love of the whole country.

Also, I want to place emphasis on the fact that when it gets to Valentine’s Day, people prefer to share other things that are promoting love. For instance, I know Ghana AIDS Commission is sharing condoms. The youth today will prefer to share those things. As we are looking at spreading love, let us seize this as an opportunity to buy more chocolate, and then share it among ourselves. I am enjoying the scene here, and as we are doing this, let us share to

in our families and constituencies as well.

In conclusion, I want to say that the industrialisation of our produce and making sure that we add value to our cocoa when we produce them is far beyond reach. We want to thank the President that as part of the 24-Hour Economy, we are going to add value to our cocoa beans before we get them out of this country. This will add up, give our youth more jobs to do, and also create an enabling environment for chocolate to be more affordable. This is so that a year by this time we could share chocolates, and then make sure our other Colleagues on the other Side equally get to partake in it. Thank you very much.

Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh (NPP — Bosome Freho): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity.

Mr Speaker, I vividly recall this day, and the *Hansards* too are here. Today marks the second time we are celebrating World Chocolate Day in this Chamber. I want to commend both Hon Members, particularly the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts and the First Deputy Majority Whip that made this Statement.

There were some profound points that were made in both Statements that I make reference to, with respect. This was said by the Minister, “Chocolate is a symbol of Ghana's agricultural excellence”. Top-notch. I want to associate heavily, with this Statement made by the Minister. The Minister again said, “when Ghanaians choose

chocolate, *fugu, et cetera* they are supporting the Ghanaian farmers”. Another excellent line that I would want to associate with. The First Deputy Chief Whip also said something, that “I urge the Government to continue to deepen the effort, especially supporting cocoa farmers”. Mr Speaker, this is another Statement made by the First Deputy Minority Whip, which I support.

Lastly, Mr Speaker, we cannot celebrate such an important chocolate day without celebrating our farmers, whom through their effort and toils, we are enjoying this cocoa. I come from a cocoa constituency. Virtually everybody in my constituency owns a cocoa farm. Mr Speaker, my Side of the House rejected the chocolate as a protest against the “haircuts” suffered by cocoa farmers. We cannot enjoy chocolate by cocoa farmers who have experienced haircuts. Mr Speaker, we rejected it and it is a sign of protest against the “haircut” experienced by cocoa farmers.

Mr Speaker, it is also important to say that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Asafo-Adjei, hold it. Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we are encouraged to be candid in our comments and submissions on the Floor. The protocol that we follow every year when this is done is that chocolates are distributed to both Sides and we have just done that. It is totally needless for him to say that his Side rejected

chocolates by way of protest; it is absolutely incorrect. He needs to withdraw that and apologise.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I indicated that when Statements are made you contribute to the Statement. If you also want to make a different Statement, you can write the Statement and bring it to be admitted.

6:20 p.m.

When it passes the test, then you can come and deliver it. We should try as much as possible to avoid making comments that are likely to generate debates. That is why Standing Order 93, which regulates Statements, is very clear that in contributing or in commenting on the Statement, you do not say anything that could generate into debates. The rule is there for a purpose. You may go ahead and conclude your comment.

Mr Ayeh: Mr Speaker, respectfully, I commend your prowess when it comes to the rudiments of the House. I do not intend to generate debate. But it must also be understood well within the space and context that, largely, when you say Statements generate into debate, it is debatable. This is because my Brother made a Statement and was referencing or inferring a 24-Hour Economy. For me, it can be a debatable issue because I do not see how the 24-Hour Economy has anything to do with chocolate. Mr Speaker, it depends on who is listening and who wants to make a debate out of anything because every word can be debatable, but respectfully, as you have said, I would respect that.

Again, Mr Speaker, a chocolate was given to my Side and we decided that we cannot take the chocolate in protest of the cocoa farmer because the cocoa farmer is not happy. I cannot enjoy a chocolate that cocoa farmers are not happy with. The cocoa farmers were given all sorts of promises. Just yesterday, before the chocolate day, the cocoa farmers were given a haircut from GHC3,600 per bag to GHC2,500, over GHC1,001. I cannot be jubilating and enjoying cocoa or chocolate on behalf of my cocoa farmers. Even when they see me on screen doing that, they would not be happy with me.

So, I want to place on record that my Side, we rejected the chocolate just in protest for the cocoa farmer. We are not taking this chocolate this year because we are not happy with how our Government is giving haircuts to the cocoa farmers.

Mr Speaker, I want to conclude by saying that we cannot have a World Chocolate Day without celebrating the cocoa farmer, protecting the cocoa farmer, or the interests of the cocoa farmer being held in high esteem. It is important that if we want to enjoy the Chocolate Day and promote chocolate, it is important that we look at the welfare of the cocoa farmer that has been neglected by the John Dramani Mahama Government.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Majority Leader, you have the floor.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, when we are doing our politics, let us do it well. Why do I say when we are doing our politics, let us do it well? He is talking about cocoa farmers, and he is saying that because of the amount the cocoa farmers are getting for their beans, he will not take chocolate. If everybody else stops taking chocolate, nobody will give them anything for their cocoa beans. *[Hear! Hear!]*

If everybody stops taking chocolate, how are they going to sell their beans? That is why I say when they are doing their politics, they should do it well. It is those who want to take chocolate who will get cocoa farmers a higher price for their beans. The cocoa beans are for chocolate making, if we do not eat chocolate, how are they going to get their money? So, he is leading a campaign for the rejection of the taking of chocolate. And it is his campaign that will hurt the farmers. So, we know them. He wants to discourage Ghanaians from taking the chocolate. We are saying that let us process the beans locally so that we will make chocolate locally, and we are encouraging every Ghanaian to take our chocolate, so that farmers can get money. He wants to incite people not to take chocolate so that farmers will not get their money.

Mr Speaker, that is why I say when they are doing their politics, they should be careful what they are saying. I am going to cause his pocket to be searched because I know there is chocolate in his pocket. His pocket should be searched. Where is the Marshal? The Marshal should go and search his pocket. After

taking the chocolate and hiding it in his pocket, he now wants to deceive other people not to take the chocolate. Mr Speaker, I think others want to make contributions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I think we can all see the reason for which the rules try to prevent us from making comments that are likely to generate debate. In commenting on Statements, there are certain things that, once you say them, it attracts response from the other Side, and then the debate begins. This is unwarranted in making Statements and in contributing to Statements.

Hon Hajia Laadi Ayamba, you have the floor.

Hajia Laadi Ayii Ayamba (NDC — Pusiga): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Statement ably made by the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts and my Sister, Hon Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe. Mr Speaker, for the four terms I have been in Parliament, we have, year in, year out, been making this Statement, and I think it is very important. We all know the importance and benefits of cocoa. We know how much it contributes to our economy and the individuals, especially farmers.

Mr Speaker, it is interesting that we all sat here today and noticed that when the boxes of chocolates were distributed, at one stage, some were sent to our Colleagues at the opposite Side. It was given directly to Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib because we want to project the use of

chocolate. And when Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib collected it, he even demanded more.

Mr Speaker, I want to state emphatically that he did the best and the right thing. We have also been on that Side; they brought chocolate, distributed it, and we took it in order to make sure that we were all on the same platform. Mr Speaker, we have said so many things year in and year out, about chocolate. But I have always, and I will continue to recommend that, due to the cost of chocolate, which has already been mentioned by some Colleagues that if we could all agree and make a recommendation that at least every pupil or student should have just one bar of chocolate, either every week or every two weeks, it will go a long way to help us.

Mr Speaker, as I am commenting on the Statement, I do not have cocoa in my area but I have the advantage of eating or tasting cocoa. But how many people, especially the students? How many of them, those who would project, those who need to understand? Even some of the farmers who produce cocoa have never eaten chocolate. We need to make concerted effort to make sure that every Ghanaian has a taste of chocolate, and it is very important.

6:30 p.m.

Mr Speaker, even as we are talking about chocolate today, I can assure you that if we say we are bringing chocolate to all MPs, all Parliamentary Service staff, we would have done a very good

job. But how many of them have had even a bar each? That is a very big question left to us. There are others that will only see us talk about it, but they have not had it. Why can we not even start from ourselves?

Mr Speaker, when we talk about production and how it can help our economy, it is the local production, and when we engage in local production, jobs will come up, a lot of people will benefit, many people will learn better and even understand the production of chocolate. So, when we talk about resetting and talk about ensuring that our economy grows, and that the 24-Hour Economy actually thrives, we are talking about local production and using our own cocoa beans. We should use our own cocoa beans and ensure that our people work and our farmers benefit from it.

Mr Speaker, I can assure you that if we go into local production seriously, even the price of our cocoa beans will increase and we will not be waiting for anybody to buy cocoa beans from us. So, if we say that it will help the resetting agenda and create more jobs, and for the 24-Hour Economy to thrive, this is what we are saying.

Mr Speaker, I thank you very much for the opportunity and I hope that next year, by this time, when we talk about chocolate, most students and people even in the rural areas will have chocolate to taste. I thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib?

Second Deputy Minority Whip (Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib): Mr Speaker, I stand first of all to commend the makers of the respective Statements, and to say that I have had the opportunity of benefiting from scholarship from COCOBOD. So, for my secondary school days, I had a full-time scholarship, and this was as a result of the support from the very hard-working cocoa farmers. From Form 1 to Form 5, I did not pay a penny. And let me take this opportunity to say kudos to all cocoa farmers, wherever they find themselves.

But Mr Speaker, what is the current situation? What is happening today? Let me quote from the Statement by the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts, and this was what she said:

“Ghana remains one of the world’s leading producers of premium quality cocoa, and the crop continues to sustain millions of livelihoods across the agricultural value chain. From our hard-working farmers and transporters, to processors, manufacturers, exporters, to retailers”.

Mr Speaker, today we are here, and there is nothing to say about the hardworking farmers. Cocoa that used to be sold for about GH¢3,600, has come down to GH¢2,500. Mr Speaker, it is like Hisense, *y’atete so se hu*, to wit, it has been reduced to nothing. This is the way we are treating cocoa farmers.

Mr Speaker, if you visit cocoa farms, as at yesterday, farmers have started

falling cocoa trees,—[Uproar]— just because of the announcement that was made yesterday. People have suffered high blood pressures which have culminated into strokes. *Omo abo ka agu*, to wit, they have suffered for nothing.

Mr Bedzrah — *rose* —

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, my Colleague on the other Side mentioned my name, you did not allow it. I am a Leader in this House, Mr Speaker, respectfully, when I am talking—Mr Speaker, with all deference to you, when Hajia Ayamba mentioned my name, you did not allow me—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let me explain to you.

Mr Shaib: Very well, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: From you speaking as a Leader—I am coming to the Leadership. He has no opportunity to speak again. And for Hajia Ayamba, I indicated to you that I will give you the floor to speak. Did I not indicate that to you?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, that is so. But I do not know why he is on his feet, so I will let you—Yes, Mr Speaker, please proceed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, do not create the impression as if I was unfair to you.

Yes, Hon Bedzrah?

Mr Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah: Mr Speaker, this is a House of Records, and I heard my Colleague, the Hon

Second Deputy Minority Whip, say on this Floor that cocoa farmers are cutting down cocoa trees. [Uproar] Mr Speaker, if he has any evidence, he should lay that evidence before you for the whole world to know that it is true that the farmers are cutting down cocoa trees.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, thank you very much. I just want to make the point that when a senior in the person of Hon Bedzrah stands on a point of order, I expect him to come under the Standing Orders and not to unnecessarily interject. This interjection was unnecessary and unheard of.

Mr Speaker, I was trying to make the point that as a beneficiary—And Mr Speaker, I have evidence. This is the evidence. Come and see the trees, and you should listen to the audio behind it. *Aye critical*. That is the evidence, and I can tender that in.

Mr Speaker, as I started saying, cocoa farmers have been the reason for which most of us have attained higher levels of education, and I am one of them. I had the opportunity of benefiting from scholarships from Form 1 to Form 5. Some of us who are seated here may also have been beneficiaries of the same scholarship.

Mr Speaker, today, the promises which were made to cocoa farmers *ato nsuom*, to wit, it is gone. It is vanished. It

is in the water. We do not know what is happening to them, and it is sad that we are here and eulogising chocolate. How do we get the beans to produce the chocolate when the cocoa farmer's farm is now being turned into *galamsey* sites? When the cocoa farmer is now suffering serious haircuts from what we call punk to *topiojo*, now to *sakora*? And we are here saying that chocolate should be part of the Black Star Experience, when the people who are supposed to benefit from the hard work as put rightly by the Minister are now the people they have come to turn into poor men and women?

Mr Speaker, let me conclude by saying that God should listen to the prayer of each and every cocoa farmer to the extent that they will not suffer from any BP, to the extent that they will not suffer from any stroke, to the extent that for all their hard work, there will be re-emergence of a party that can save them, for them to have their cocoa grown and grown in a better environment, so that they can earn proper living, and that it will not be the paltry sum that they are currently receiving.

Mr Speaker, I thank you very much for this opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leadership?

6:40 p.m.

Majority Chief Whip (Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor): Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to comment on the Statement made by the Hon Minister for

Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts to commemorate the day as World Chocolate Day.

Mr Speaker, I have been in this House for about nine years, and every year we do this. But for the first time, we have departed from the terms of the Statement and gone to town. Mr Speaker, I was here when the Government brought a facility agreement to this House, as it were, from the African Development Bank to extend cocoa farms in this country, rehabilitate, irrigate, resurvey them, and treat swollen stool disease. The record will bear me out. The Auditor-General's report of 2024 will bear me out. There was a US\$334 million drawdown from the US\$500 million granted. Yet, the cocoa farms were not irrigated, the swollen stool diseases were not treated, the farms were not extended, and new seedlings were not distributed to farmers. The roads that they told us, the cocoa roads that they would do, were not extended to the farms.

Mr Speaker, the end result was that our tonnage in excess of one million metric tonnes dropped to 450,000 metric tonnes as at the end of December 2024. So, the problems the farmers are facing now were the ones Hon Jerry Shaib and his Side left. And while this Government is taking pragmatic, proactive steps to reform the sector, Hon Jerry says we should not celebrate World Chocolate Day or eat chocolate.

Mr Speaker, as my Leader said, we will do everything we can to revitalise the cocoa farms so that the beans that

farmers are crying that they do not have markets for, or whose prices are low, will be boosted. So that they can have high prices for their yield. As we speak, the Minister for Finance has given directions that the cocoa farmers be paid. What is the issue? Last year, when the Government increased the prices of cocoa, the Minority said, why did the Government not raise the prices of cocoa in response to the world market price? Today, the Government is fixing cocoa prices in accordance with the world market price. They say they do not know. So, when we increase prices, and it is not according to the world market price, we have a problem.

When we adjust prices according to the world market price, they have a problem. Mr Speaker, we will leave the tangential to the substantive. The issue is that today is World Chocolate Day, and we are being encouraged to celebrate it. We are encouraged to do so because many factories process these chocolates, even in Ghana. Foreigners are encouraged to patronise it so the factories can expand and more jobs can be created. That is what I think we should focus on. We are tying this to our identity, as last Wednesday was declared National Fugu Day. And if we begin to do things like this, it will boost our local factories, create more jobs, and the economy will blossom.

So, I want to invite the Minority Side not play politics with everything. When we are confronted with issues that have to do with the national identity, we need to unite and speak to certain factors that will promote our national identity.

Mr Speaker, I want to urge everyone to replicate this in our various constituencies, so that every year we can do this, even in a selected school in our constituencies. I want to thank the Minister for bringing this to the attention of the House. I want to encourage the Hon Minister to encourage institutions under her to do this in their respective regions and districts.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity. The politics must end. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Statement time has ended.

Hon Members, I hope you have enjoyed the contributions to the Statements on World Chocolate Day. I have not enjoyed it because you have all departed from the very reason underpinning the making of the Statement, using the opportunity wrongly to engage in politicking and debating. Hon Members, going forward, let us reflect on our rules and be guided anytime Statements are made, and comments are welcome on the Statement.

Having ended the Statement time, Majority Leader, is there any indication?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may we pray that we take item numbered 1 on *Order Paper Addendum 2*.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the application is to take item number 1 on *Order Paper Addendum 2*

Mr Shaib: Yes, Mr Speaker, we are not opposed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

PAPER

By Chairperson of the Committee—

Report of the Committee on Energy on the Master Gas Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Finance and the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC), GNPC Exploration and Production Limited, Tullow Ghana Limited, Kosmos Energy Ghana HC, Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments, and PetroSA Ghana Limited (as Contractor Parties).

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, a sense of the House is that we bring the curtains down for today's Business. By my reckoning, we have not done for five hours, and therefore I *move* that in the absence of any further Business, the House be adjourned to Tuesday, 2 p.m.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was accordingly adjourned at 6:51 p.m. till Tuesday, 17th February, 2026 at 2:00 p.m.

Editor's Note

This *Official Report* was corrected by the House on 19th February, 2026.

Column 112, paragraph 3, line 3,
“Congress” was inserted after
“Democratic” to read “National
Democratic Congress”.